



Barriers of Mobility:

Visa Issues for Non-EU Students

2026 Edition

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Preface

The Barriers of Mobility: Visa Issues for Non-EU Students – 2026 Edition represents more than a collection of responses; it reflects the shared aspirations, concerns, and lived experiences of non-EU students engaging with international mobility. In an increasingly interconnected world, the opportunity to study abroad is often regarded as a transformative journey, one that fosters academic growth, intercultural understanding, and personal development. However, for many non-EU students, this journey is not without its challenges.

This report aims to explore the barriers that non-EU students encounter throughout the mobility process, with particular attention to administrative, financial, and institutional obstacles. Rather than merely documenting these difficulties, the survey seeks to identify patterns, amplify student voices, and contribute to the ongoing dialogue on how mobility programmes can become more inclusive and accessible.

As international education continues to evolve, understanding these barriers for non-EU students is essential for institutions, policymakers, and student organisations alike. By shedding light on these experiences, we hope to encourage more responsive support systems and to promote equitable access to mobility opportunities for all non-EU students.

Ultimately, this report is guided by the belief that mobility should not be a privilege for a few, but a realistic and attainable opportunity for every non-EU student, regardless of their background.

National Development Committee
ESN Türkiye
(2025–2026)



Introduction

The Barriers of Mobility: Visa Issues for Non-EU Students – 2026 Edition is a research initiative dedicated to examining the challenges faced by non-EU students and young people in accessing international mobility opportunities. Building on previous research and advocacy efforts, this edition focuses specifically on visa and residence permit procedures and their impact on participation in programmes such as Erasmus+ Studies, Erasmus+ Internship, and other mobility schemes. As global mobility continues to play a central role in higher education, ensuring equal access to these opportunities remains a key priority for stakeholders across Europe and beyond.

Despite the inclusive vision of international programmes, non-EU participants continue to encounter significant structural barriers that limit their ability to fully benefit from these experiences. This survey collects first-hand experiences from non-EU students and young people, exploring all stages of the process, including access to information, application procedures, institutional support, processing times, rejection outcomes, and the broader impact of visa-related issues on participants' motivation, well-being, and overall mobility experience. By capturing both quantitative and qualitative data, it ensures that participant voices are reflected in a meaningful and representative way.

The findings offer timely, evidence-based insights that identify gaps within existing systems and highlight areas where improvements are urgently needed. The results will be compiled into a comprehensive report and shared with key stakeholders, including policymakers, educational institutions, and international organisations, with the dual purpose of amplifying the real experiences of non-EU participants and providing actionable recommendations for more accessible, transparent, and fair mobility systems. Ultimately, this initiative aims to contribute to a future where international mobility is truly inclusive, and where all individuals, regardless of their passport, can equally benefit from the opportunities it offers.

Methodology

The Barriers of Mobility: Visa Issues for Non-EU Students 2026 Edition was designed to provide comprehensive insights into the visa and residence permit related challenges faced by non-EU students and young people participating in international mobility programmes. Building on previous research conducted within the Erasmus Student Network (ESN) Türkiye and related initiatives, this edition adopts a more structured and policy-oriented approach, focusing on the systemic barriers that affect access to mobility opportunities across Europe. As international mobility continues to expand, ensuring equitable access remains a key priority, making it essential to better understand how administrative procedures shape participation and experience.

This edition introduces a more structured, modular, and condition-based survey design to provide a more precise and comprehensive understanding of participants' experiences. The questionnaire is organised into a screening section, programme-specific pathways, and thematic modules activated through routing logic, allowing respondents to be directed only to the sections relevant to their mobility profile and administrative experience. This approach supports a more targeted data collection process and improves the survey's ability to capture variation across different mobility pathways.

The analytical scope of the survey has also been significantly expanded. This edition examines the visa and residence permit process across all major stages, including pre-application decision-making, institutional support, embassy and application experience, processing times and costs, rejection and transparency mechanisms, and the broader effects of these procedures on participants' wellbeing and perception of equality. In addition, the survey includes more structured questions on financial burden, appointment systems, indirect costs, and post-arrival residence permit procedures. These additions make it possible to explore more clearly how administrative systems shape both access to mobility and the overall participant experience, while also generating evidence that can better support policy and advocacy efforts.

The scope of the survey has also been expanded to better reflect the diversity of mobility pathways. In addition, respondents who were unable to participate in mobility due to visa-related barriers were included through a dedicated section. This broader scope allows for a more comprehensive understanding of both realised and unrealised mobility experiences, ensuring that the findings capture the full extent of barriers faced by non-EU participants.

Survey Design and Structure

The survey was designed as a structured data collection tool to capture the experiences of non-EU students and young people in relation to visa and residence permit procedures. Building on previous survey, this edition introduces a more modular and process-oriented approach, allowing for a clearer understanding of how administrative procedures affect mobility participation.

The questionnaire is organised into an initial background section followed by programme-specific pathways and thematic modules. Respondents are guided through the survey based on their answers, ensuring that each participant is directed only to the sections relevant to their mobility experience. This structure enables both targeted data collection and comparability across different participant groups.

The survey covers the full mobility journey, including pre-application considerations, institutional support, visa application processes, processing timelines and costs, and post-arrival administrative procedures. It also examines the broader impact of these processes on participants' experiences, including academic engagement, financial planning, and well-being.

In addition to participants who completed or are currently engaged in mobility, the survey also includes respondents who were unable to participate due to visa-related barriers. This allows for a more comprehensive understanding of both realised and unrealised mobility experiences.

It should also be noted that certain survey items, particularly ranking-based questions, included explanatory descriptions within the questionnaire to clarify response options. While these clarifications were provided to respondents during data collection, they were not directly reflected in the graphical outputs. Instead, they were retained for interpretation and explicitly addressed within the analytical sections of the report to ensure accurate contextual understanding of the findings.

Data Collection and Analysis

The study was conducted as a mixed-methods research project, combining quantitative and qualitative data. The survey was administered online between 19 January 2026 and 19 March 2026, allowing participants to respond remotely and anonymously.

The questionnaire was disseminated through ESN local sections, National Organisations, and partner institutions, mainly via social media, university networks, and direct outreach to students. This helped ensure a diverse range of respondents across countries and mobility programmes.

Following the data collection phase, responses were reviewed to ensure data quality. Duplicate and incomplete entries were removed, and the dataset was cleaned for analysis. Quantitative data was analysed using descriptive statistics to identify key trends and patterns, while qualitative responses were examined to capture recurring themes and provide additional context to the findings.

Limitations

Some limitations should be considered when interpreting the results. First, the survey relies on self-reported data, which may reflect subjective perceptions and personal experiences rather than objective institutional conditions.

Second, the overall number of responses may be considered a limitation in terms of sample size. However, this is partly balanced by the diversity of the sample, which includes respondents from different mobility pathways, institutional contexts, and administrative experiences. In addition, the qualitative elements of the survey, such as responses provided under “other” options and the final overall feedback section, offer valuable contextual insights that complement the quantitative findings and strengthen the interpretation of the results.

Another limitation relates to the composition of the sample, particularly the concentration of passport holders and sending countries in Türkiye. This may affect the broader representativeness of the findings. At the same time, the responses suggest that visa and residence permit experiences reported by participants connected to Türkiye show substantial similarities with those of respondents from less represented groups. While the sample is weighted towards one particular context, the challenges identified within that group appear to be broadly consistent with the experiences described across the rest of the sample.

Finally, differences in visa and residence permit systems across countries limit direct comparability, as procedures and administrative practices vary significantly. Despite these limitations, the dataset provides valuable insight into the barriers faced by non-EU participants and offers a useful basis for further analysis and policy discussion.



Chapter 1

Respondent Profile & Mobility Background



In this section, we begin by examining the profile of the 530 survey respondents. Rather than demographic characteristics such as age or gender, the Barriers of Mobility survey focuses on mobility-related background variables that are directly relevant to the visa and administrative experiences documented throughout this report.

These include programme type and participation status, passport country and type, the semester in which the most recent programme took place, programme duration for Erasmus+ and other mobility participants, full degree level and prior educational attainment for full degree participants, field of study, prior international travel experience, sending and host country, grant status for Erasmus+ participants, funding arrangements for full degree participants, and visa and residence permit requirement status.

Together, these variables provide the contextual foundation necessary for interpreting the findings in the sections that follow, and allow for a clearer understanding of who participated in the survey and under what circumstances they engaged with international mobility.

1.1. Passport Country & Passport Type

As illustrated in Figure 1, the sample spans a geographically diverse range of countries. Türkiye accounts for the largest share at 84.9% (450 respondents), followed by Asia, the Middle East & Africa (11.3%, 60), Non-EU European countries (2.5%, 13), and the Americas (1.3%, 7). Since visa systems and consular practices are determined primarily by the host country rather than the specific passport held, the findings are broadly representative of the wider non-EU mobility experience.

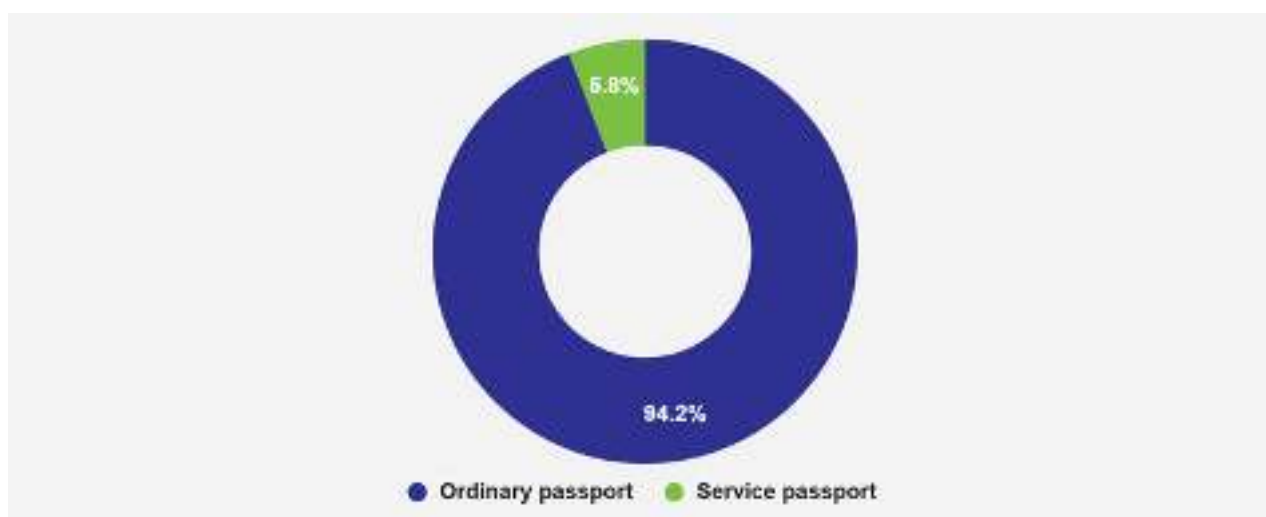
Figure 1



Geographical Distribution of Respondents by Passport Country (N=530)

94.2% of respondents (499) hold an ordinary standard passport and 5.8% (31) hold a service or official passport (Figure 2). It is worth noting that service or official passport holders may be subject to different visa requirements depending on bilateral agreements between their sending and host country, and in some cases may be visa-exempt while still being required to obtain a residence permit upon arrival. Unless otherwise specified, findings throughout this report reflect the combined sample across both passport types.

Figure 2



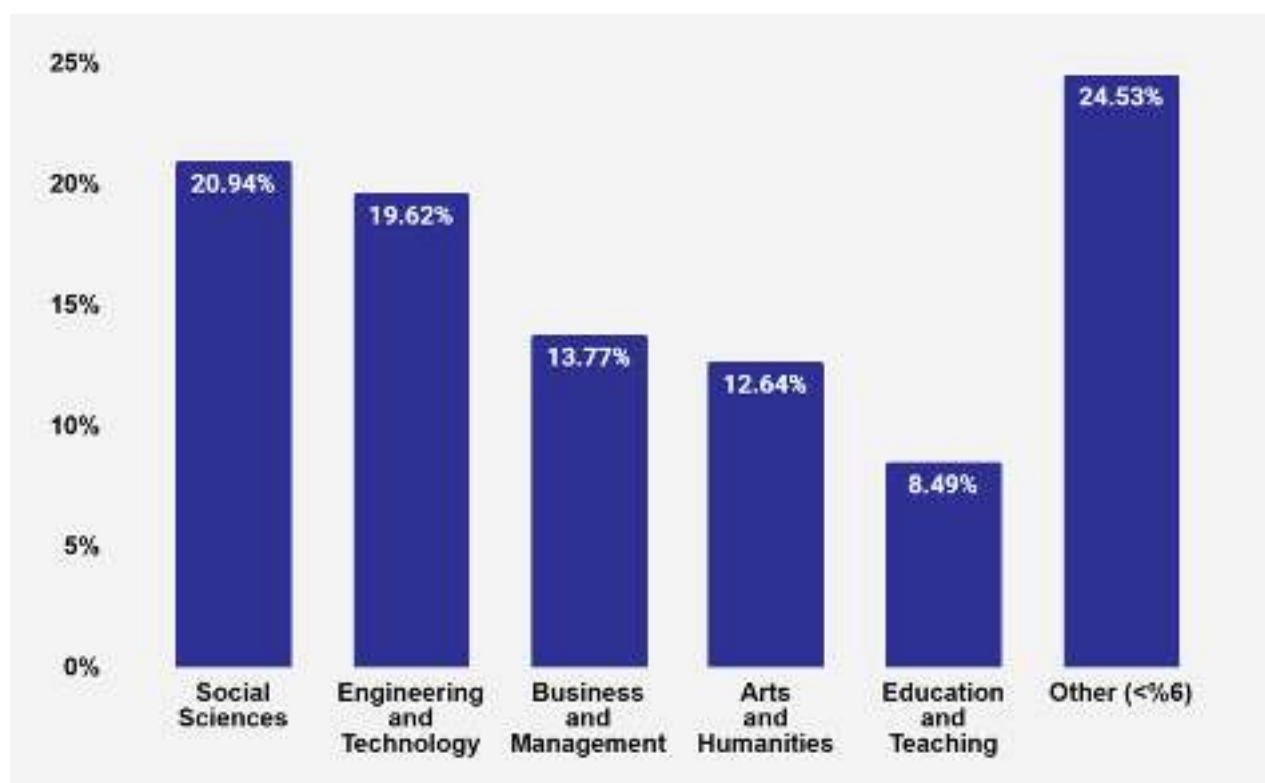
Distribution of Respondents by Passport Type (N=530)

1.2. Field of Study

Social Sciences represents the largest group at 20.94%, followed by Engineering and Technology (19.62%) and Business and Management (13.77%). Arts and Humanities account for 12.64% and Education and Teaching for 8.49%. The remaining fields each represent smaller shares, including Health and Medicine, Science and Technology (both 5.7%), Natural Sciences (5.3%), Design and Architecture (4.2%), Law and Legal Studies (1.9%), Agriculture and Food Sciences (1.1%), and Communication and Media (0.8%) (Figure 3).

The diversity of academic backgrounds ensures that the findings are not skewed towards any single field, lending the results a degree of generalisability across the wider non-EU student population.

Figure 3



Distribution of Respondents by Field of Study (N=530)

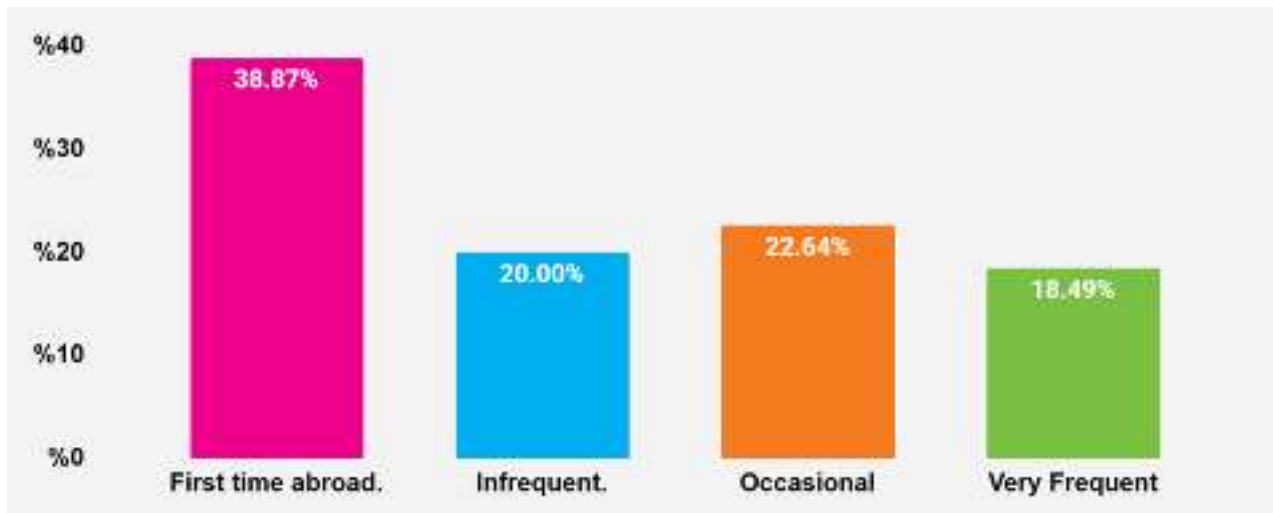
1.3. Prior Travel Experience

38.87% (206 respondents) had no prior international travel experience, making this their first time abroad. A further 20.0% (106) were infrequent travellers, 22.64% (120) occasional travellers, and 18.49% (98) very frequent travellers with multiple trips per year (Figure 4).

Nearly six in ten respondents had limited or no prior experience navigating international administrative systems before embarking on their mobility. For many, the visa application process was not only their first encounter with consular bureaucracy but also their first exposure to international administrative demands.

The challenges documented in subsequent sections were faced disproportionately by participants with little to no prior framework for understanding what to expect or how to respond when difficulties arose, and for many, mobility programmes such as Erasmus+ represent a genuine gateway to international experience rather than an addition to an already established pattern of cross-border movement.

Figure 4



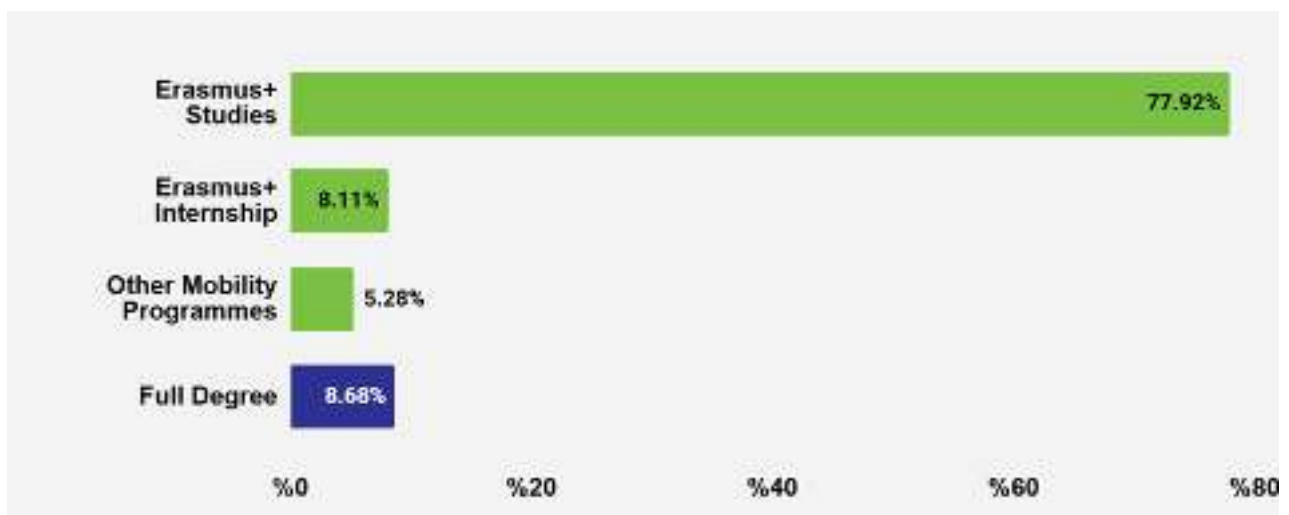
Distribution of Respondents by Prior Travel Experience (N=530)

1.4. Mobility Type

Respondents were grouped into four categories: Erasmus+ Studies, Erasmus+ Internship, Full Degree, and Other Mobility Programmes. The last encompasses Erasmus+ Projects, Youth Opportunities, Blended Intensive Programmes, International Credit Mobility, ESC, and other programmes beyond Erasmus+.

Erasmus+ Studies is by far the most represented at 77.92% (413), followed by Full Degree at 8.68% (46), Erasmus+ Internship at 8.11% (43), and Other Mobility Programmes at 5.28% (28) (Figure 5).

Figure 5

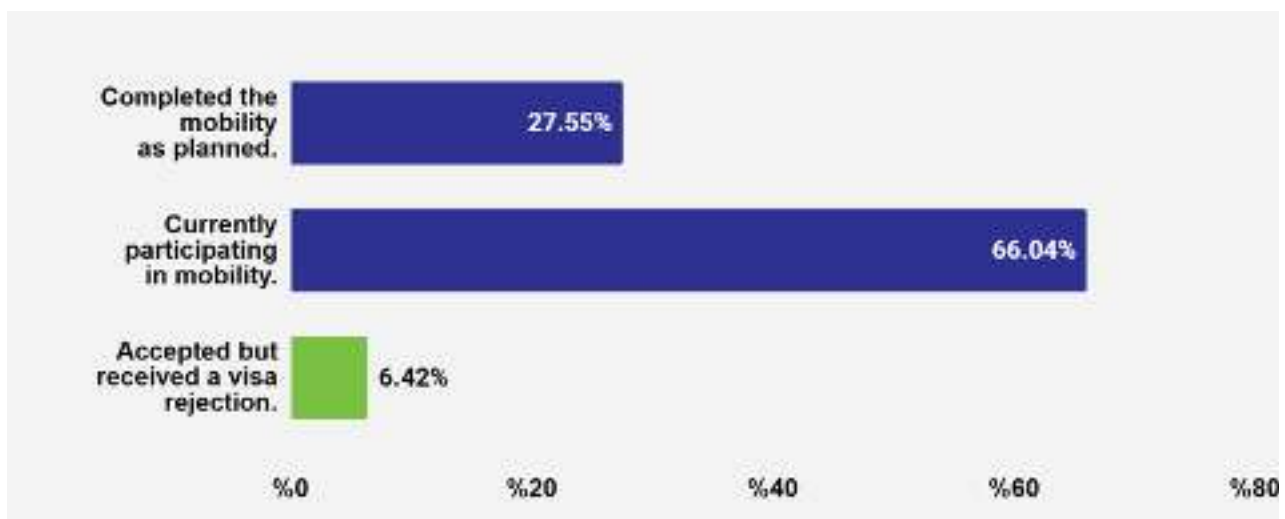


Distribution of Participants by Mobility Type

1.5. Programme Status

Respondents were asked to indicate the current status of their mobility programme. As shown in Figure 6, the majority (66.04%, 350 respondents) were currently participating at the time of the survey, and 27.55% (146 respondents) had completed their mobility as planned. 6.42% (34 respondents) had been accepted to a programme but were ultimately unable to participate due to a visa rejection.

Figure 6



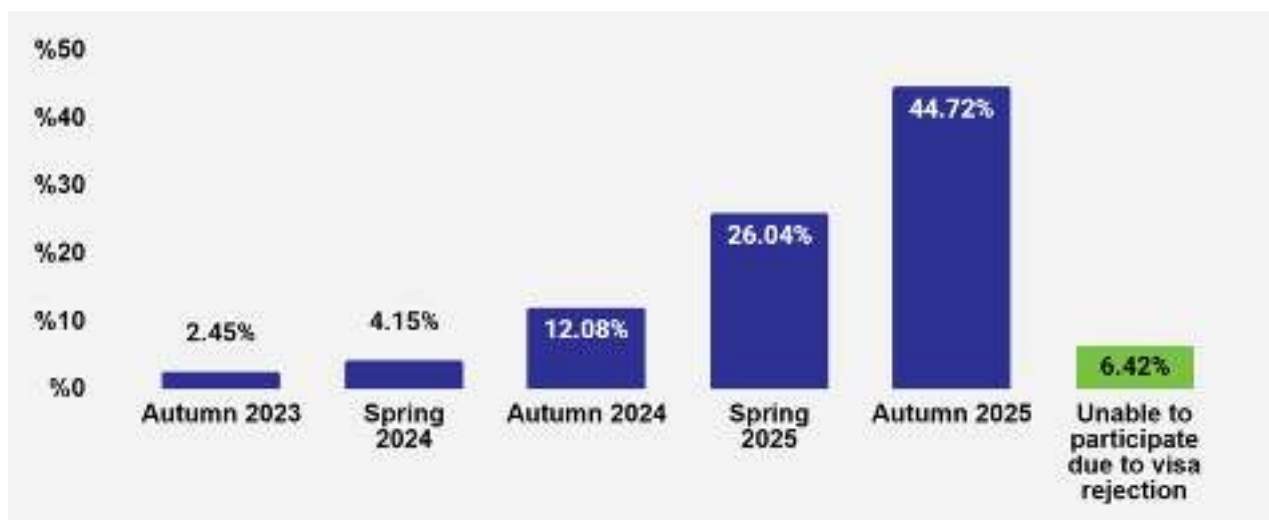
Distribution of Participants by Programme Status (N=530)

1.6. Mobility Period and Duration

Respondents were asked to indicate the most recent semester in which their programme took place, capturing mobility experiences spanning from before August 2023 through to Autumn 2025. Autumn 2025 is the most represented at 44.72% (237 respondents), followed by Spring 2025 at 26.04% (138) and Autumn 2024 at 12.08% (64). Spring 2024 and the period before August 2023 each account for 4.15% (22), and Autumn 2023 for 2.45% (13). 6.42% (34 respondents) were unable to participate due to a visa rejection and are therefore not associated with a specific semester (Figure 7).

The distribution across six academic periods ensures that the sample captures a range of administrative experiences rather than reflecting a single point in time. The strong concentration in the 2024-2025 academic year nonetheless means that the findings predominantly represent current consular and institutional practices, strengthening their immediate applicability for ongoing advocacy and policy discussions.

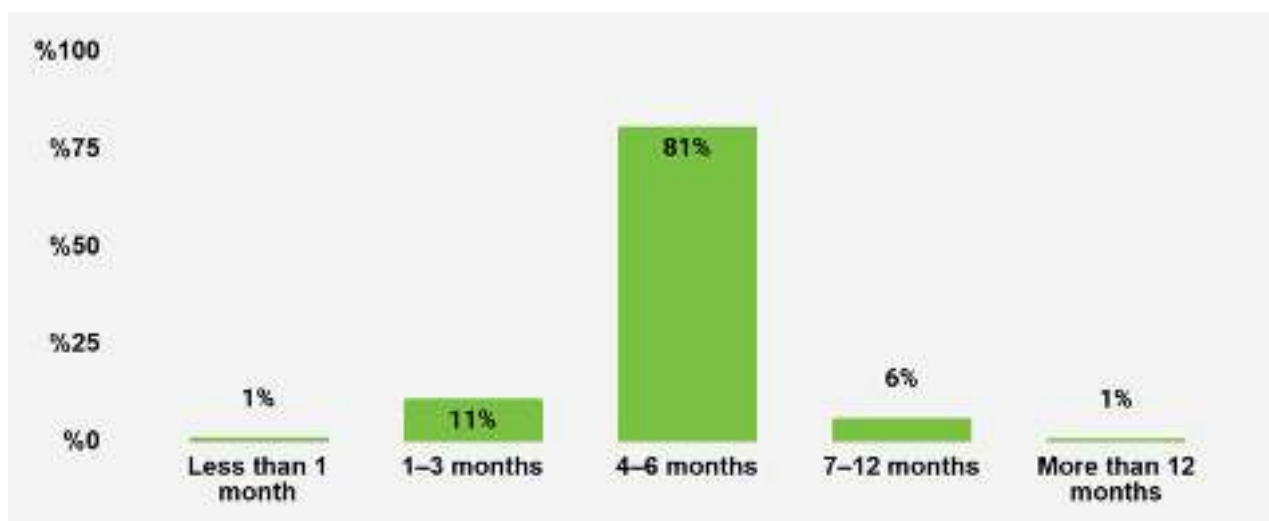
Figure 7



Distribution of Participants by the Most Recent Mobility Period (N=530)

Among the 484 Erasmus+ and other mobility participants, 81.0% (392) participated in programmes of 4-6 months, corresponding to a standard academic semester. 11.0% (53) participated in programmes of 1-3 months, 6.0% (30) in programmes of 7-12 months, 1.0% (5) in programmes of less than one month, and 1.0% (4) in programmes exceeding 12 months (Figure 8).

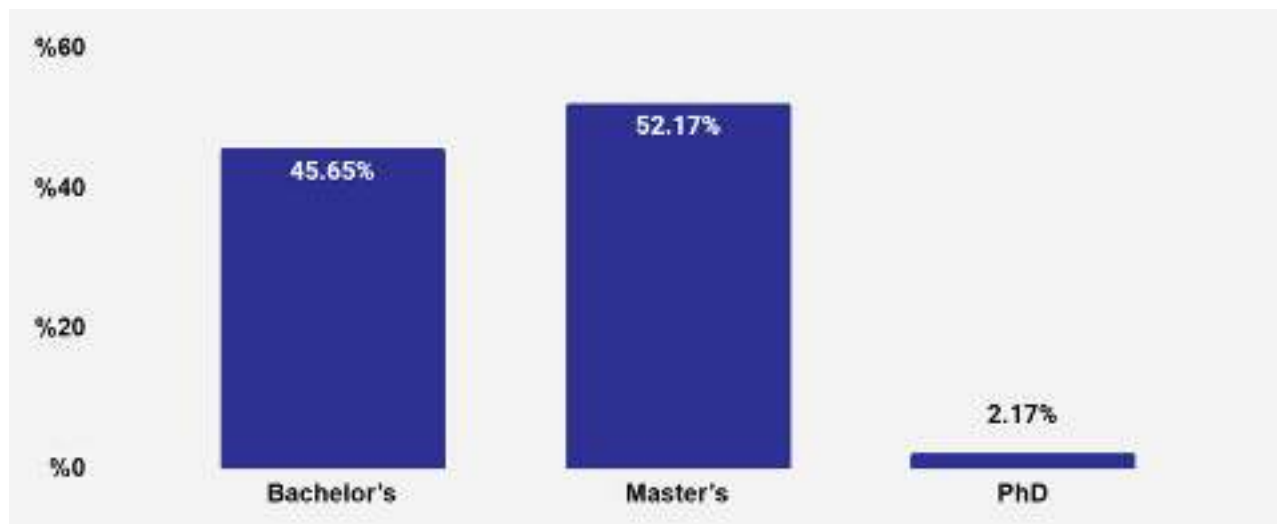
Figure 8



Distribution of Participants by Mobility Period (N=50)

Among respondents applying for full degree programmes, Master's degrees constitute the largest share at 52.17% (24 respondents), followed by Bachelor's degrees at 45.65% (21 respondents), while PhD programmes represent only 2.17% (1 respondent) (Figure 9). This indicates that full degree applications are concentrated primarily at the Master's and Bachelor's levels, with doctoral-level participation remaining very limited.

Figure 9



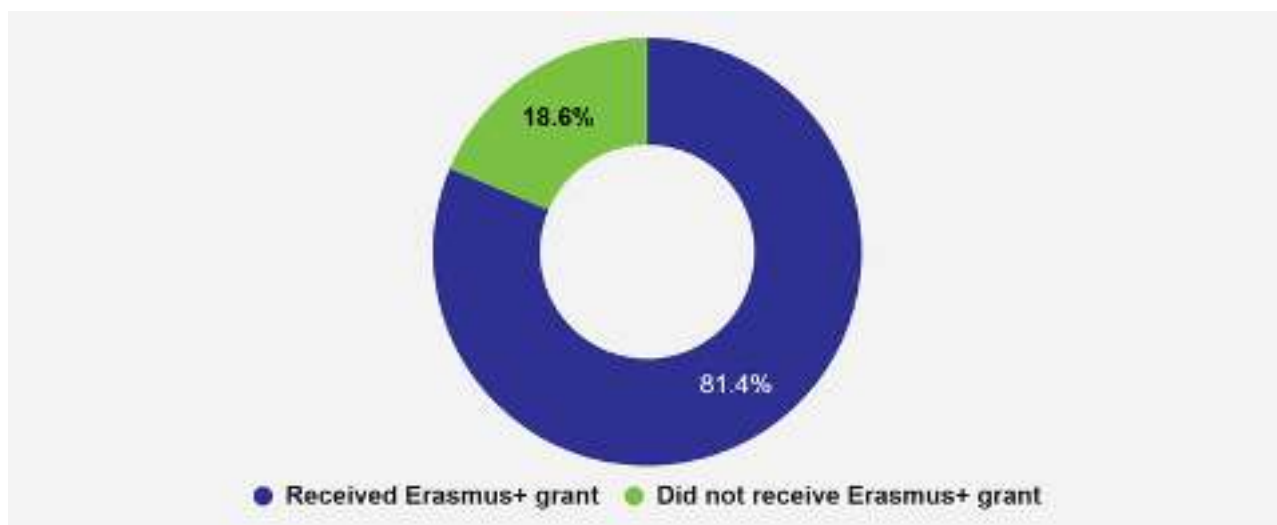
Distribution of Full Degree Participants by Programme Type (N=46)

1.7. Programme Funding

Funding arrangements are reported separately for Erasmus+ and other mobility participants and full degree students, reflecting the distinct funding structures of the two groups.

Among the 456 Erasmus+ programme participants who responded to this question, 81.4% (371) received an Erasmus+ grant for their mobility and 18.6% (85) did not (Figure 10). It should be noted that ESC participants and those on other mobility programmes outside the Erasmus+ framework were not directed to this question, as a distinct Erasmus+ grant structure does not apply to their programmes.

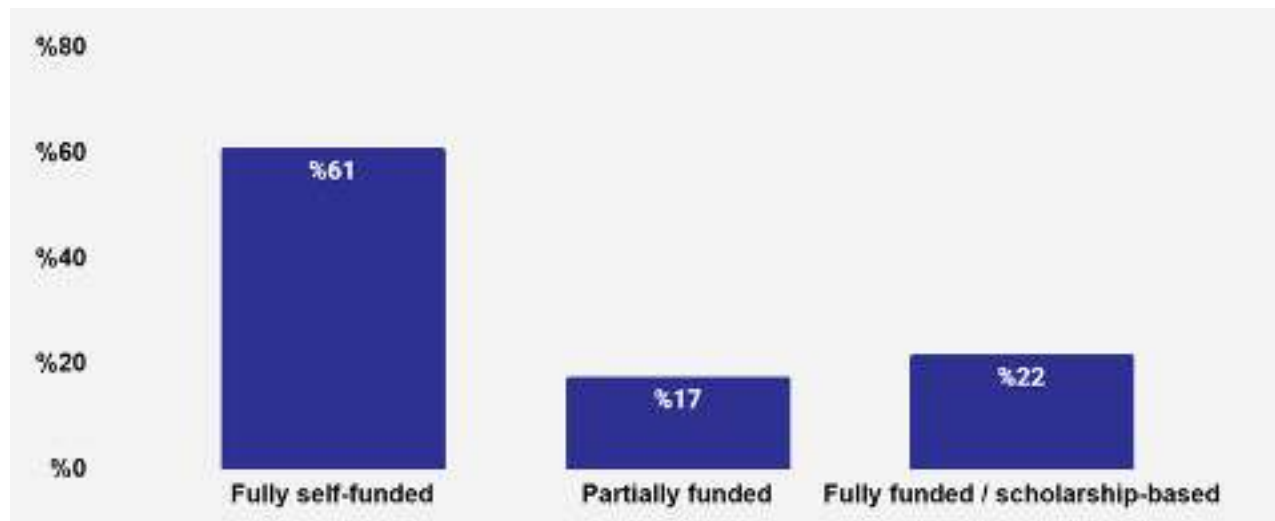
Figure 10



Distribution of Participants by Erasmus+ Programme Funding (N=456)

Among the 46 full degree participants, the funding picture is markedly different. The majority were fully self-funded at 61% (28), reflecting the absence of a standardised grant framework comparable to Erasmus+. 22% (10) were fully funded through a scholarship and 17% (8) were partially funded (Figure 11).

Figure 11



Distribution of Participants by Full Degree Programme Funding (N=46)

1.8. Sending & Host Country

On the sending side, Türkiye accounts for 87.5% (464 respondents), followed by Asia, the Middle East & Africa at 5.1% (27), EU Member States at 4.5% (24), Non-EU European countries at 1.5% (8), and the Americas at 1.3% (7) (Figure 12). As visa requirements are determined by passport nationality rather than the location of the sending institution, the administrative experiences documented throughout this report reflect respondents' status as non-EU passport holders irrespective of their sending country.

Figure 12



Distribution of Participants by Sending Country (N=464)

On the receiving side, 93.6% of respondents (496) undertook their mobility in EU Member States, with Türkiye hosting 18 respondents (3.4%), Non-EU European countries 10 (1.9%), Asia & the Middle East 5 (0.9%), and the Americas 1 (0.2%) (Figure 13).

Figure 13



Distribution of Participants by Host Country (N=530)

1.9. Visa & Residence Permit Requirements

94.9% of respondents (503) were required to obtain a visa, while 5.1% (27) were not (Figure 14). Residence permit requirements present a more even split, with 50.4% (267) required to obtain one upon arrival and 49.6% (263) not (Figure 15).

240 respondents (45.3%) faced both obligations, representing the most administratively demanding profile within the sample. Notably, all 27 visa-exempt respondents were still required to obtain a residence permit, meaning no respondent was entirely free from at least one administrative obligation.

Figure 14



Visa Requirement (N=530)

Figure 15



Residence Permit Requirement (N=530)

These figures establish the administrative landscape within which the vast majority of respondents experienced their mobility. For nearly half the sample, international participation did not conclude with a granted visa but extended into a second layer of post-arrival bureaucracy, creating a prolonged period of administrative uncertainty that stretched from the pre-departure phase through to the early weeks of the programme itself.

The near-universal prevalence of at least one formal administrative requirement across the entire sample reflects the structural reality faced by non-EU participants. Regardless of the specific programme, duration, or destination, engagement with immigration systems is not an occasional inconvenience but a near-certain feature of the mobility experience. What differs between respondents is not whether they encountered administrative obligations, but how many layers of procedure they were required to navigate and at what personal, financial, and academic cost.

This dual-requirement landscape also has implications for how the findings in this report should be read. The visa and residence permit processes are not isolated procedures but sequential stages of a broader administrative journey, each with its own institutional actors, timelines, costs, and points of potential failure. The sections that follow examine each stage in detail, beginning with the pre-application phase and the factors that shaped respondents' decision to pursue mobility in the first place, and concluding with the residence permit procedure and the rights restrictions that delays in that process can produce.



Chapter 2

Pre-Application



The pre-application phase represents a critical stage in the mobility journey, during which prospective participants form their initial intentions, evaluate possible destinations, and begin to anticipate the practical requirements of studying or training abroad. At this point, decisions are often shaped not only by academic aspirations and personal motivations, but also by the perceived complexity and accessibility of administrative procedures, particularly those related to visas.

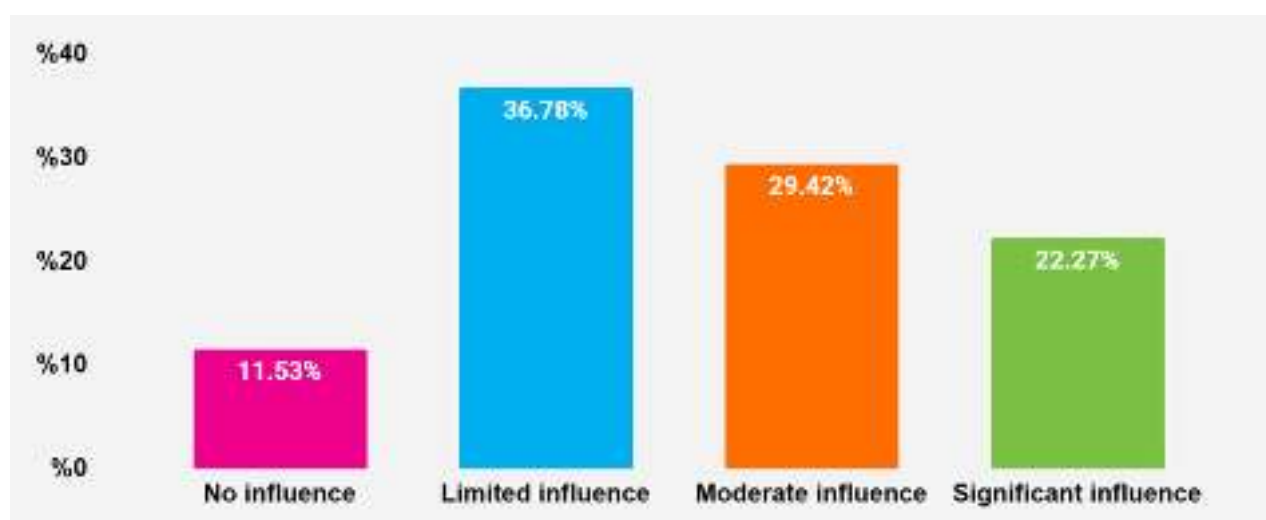
This chapter explores how visa-related factors influence individuals before they formally apply to mobility programmes. It examines the extent to which such considerations affect motivation to apply, shape the choice of host country or institution, and influence early financial planning. In addition, it looks at the sources of information that respondents rely on when navigating visa requirements, highlighting the role of both formal and informal channels in supporting decision-making.

By focusing on this initial stage, the chapter aims to provide a clearer understanding of how perceived administrative barriers can shape participation even before the application process begins. The findings offer insight into the ways in which uncertainty, access to information, and procedural expectations may encourage, delay, or discourage engagement with international mobility opportunities.

2.1 Influence on Motivation to Apply

Visa-related factors appear to have influenced respondents' initial motivation to apply for mobility programmes to varying degrees. The fact that 11.53% of respondents (58 participants) indicated that these factors played no role in their decision suggests that, for a limited group, visa procedures remained outside the scope of their application decision-making. However, 36.78% of respondents (185 participants) reported being aware of visa requirements, while indicating that these did not meaningfully alter their intention to apply. In contrast, 29.42% (148 participants) reported that visa-related considerations created a certain level of hesitation prior to applying.

Figure 16



Influence of Visa-Related Factors on Motivation to Apply for Mobility Programmes (N=503)

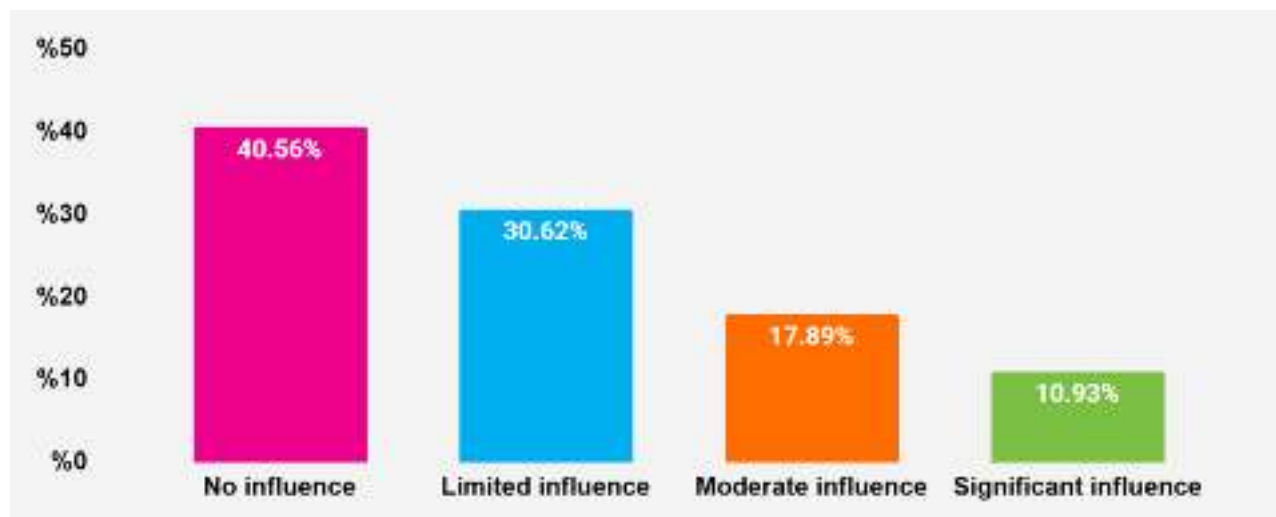
More notably, for 22.27% of respondents (112), these factors appear to have been considerably more decisive, even raising the possibility of not applying altogether (Figure 16). Overall, these findings suggest that visa-related concerns do not affect all participants in the same way; however, for the majority, they form a noticeable element within the decision-making process, influencing motivation to varying degrees.

2.2 Influence on Choice of Host Country or Institution

Visa-related considerations appear to have had a more limited influence on the choice of host country or institution compared to their effect on initial motivation to apply. The fact that 40.56% of respondents (204 participants) reported no influence suggests that a considerable proportion based their choices primarily on academic or professional considerations.

At the same time, 30.62% (154 participants) indicated that visa-related factors were taken into account during the selection process, but were not decisive. In contrast, 17.89% of respondents (90 participants) reported avoiding certain destinations because of visa-related procedures. A smaller but notable group, representing 10.93% of respondents (55 participants), stated that they made their choice largely on the basis of destinations offering simpler or more predictable visa procedures (Figure 17).

Figure 17



Influence of Visa-Related Factors on Choice of Host Country or Institution (N= 503)

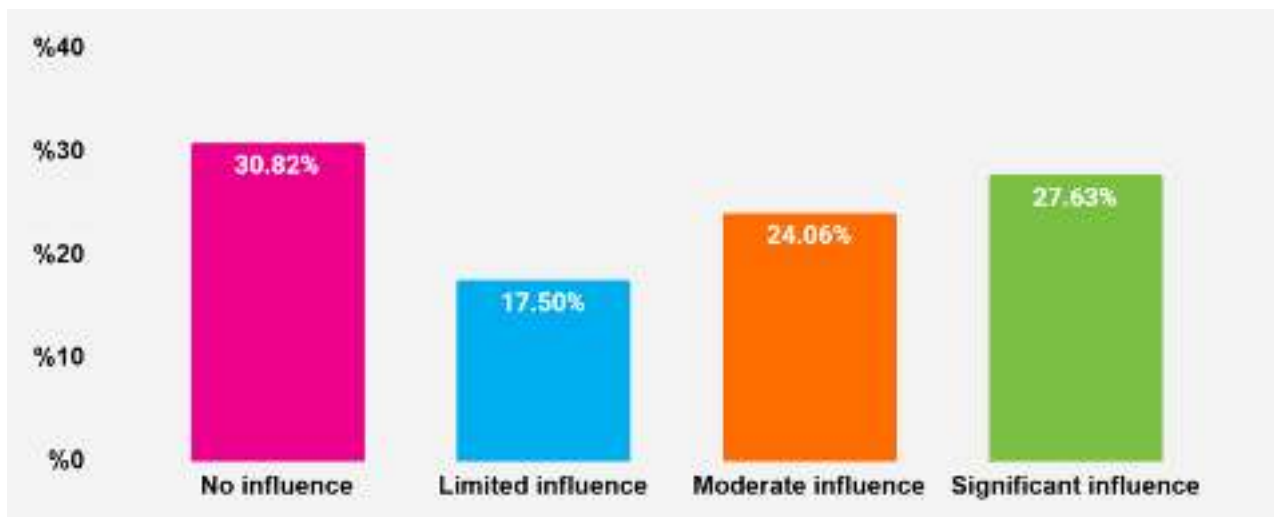
Overall, this distribution suggests that visa-related factors were not the dominant determinant for all participants, but for some applicants they shaped how options were assessed, leading to more cautious or strategic selection patterns.

2.3. Influence on Financial Planning

Visa-related considerations appear to have had a more pronounced effect on financial planning. The fact that 30.82% of respondents (155 participants) reported no influence suggests that this group was able to proceed with financial commitments according to their original plans. However, for the majority of respondents, uncertainty related to the visa process appears to have affected financial decisions to some extent.

17.50% of respondents (88 participants) reported limited influence, indicating that some bookings were delayed without major financial consequences. In contrast, 24.06% (121 participants) reported a moderate level of influence, suggesting that postponing bookings resulted in higher costs.

Figure 18



Influence of Visa-Related Factors on Financial Planning (N=503)

More notably, 27.63% of respondents (139 participants) indicated a significant influence, reflecting situations where uncertainty led participants to choose more expensive or refundable options (Figure 18).

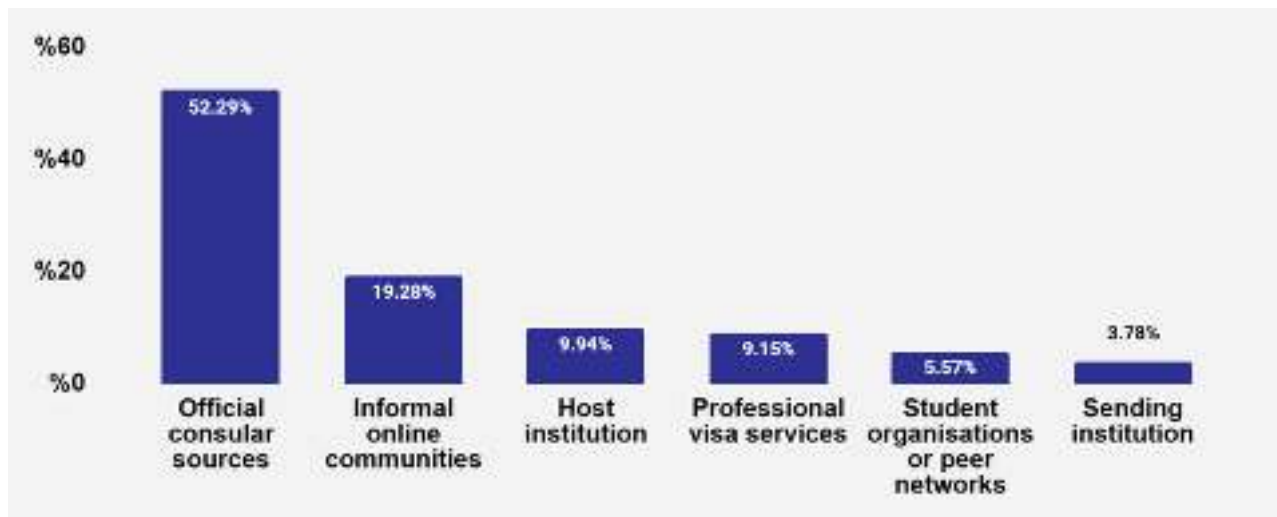
Overall, this distribution suggests that visa-related uncertainty affects financial planning not only in terms of timing but also in terms of cost structure. Particularly among those reporting moderate and significant influence, respondents appear to have adopted more flexible but often more expensive arrangements in order to manage uncertainty within the process.

2.4. Sources of Visa-Related Information

When seeking information about visa procedures, respondents relied primarily on official consular channels, with 52.29% (263 respondents) indicating that they used information made available through embassy or consulate websites, official guidance, or direct communication. This suggests that formal institutional sources remain the main point of reference for understanding administrative requirements (Figure 19).

At the same time, 19.28% of respondents (97) turned to informal online spaces such as social media platforms, forums, or messaging groups, pointing to the relevance of peer-generated information in supporting the process.

Figure 19



Sources of Visa-Related Information Among Respondents (N=503)

The distribution highlights a layered information ecosystem. While official sources provide the primary framework, a considerable share of respondents appear to seek additional clarity or reassurance through less formal channels. This may reflect a perceived need to interpret or contextualise official information, particularly in situations where procedures are experienced as complex or evolving.

Other sources of information included the host institution (9.94%, 50), which may provide guidance on destination-specific visa requirements; professional visa services (9.15%, 46), involving support from agencies or paid consultants; student organisations or peer networks such as ESN (5.57%, 28); and the sending institution (3.78%, 19), typically through the international office of the home institution.

Overall, the distribution points to a layered information environment. Although official consular sources constitute the primary basis for navigating procedures, a substantial proportion of respondents appear to complement this information with support from institutions, service providers, and peer-based channels. This pattern may indicate that applicants seek not only formal instructions, but also clarification, interpretation, and practical reassurance when dealing with procedures that may be perceived as complex or subject to change.



Chapter 3

Institutional Information & Support

Institutional support plays a critical role in shaping students' experiences throughout the mobility process, particularly in relation to visa and residence permit procedures. As administrative requirements become increasingly complex and time-sensitive, the extent to which sending and host institutions provide clear, accurate, and timely guidance can significantly influence participants' ability to navigate these processes effectively.

This chapter examines how respondents perceive and evaluate the support received from both sending and host institutions, with a specific focus on visa-related guidance. It explores not only the availability of information, but also its quality, clarity, and relevance to individual circumstances. In doing so, the analysis highlights the degree to which institutional structures succeed in facilitating mobility, as well as the gaps that may leave participants reliant on their own resources.

Beyond general evaluations, the chapter also investigates the specific challenges encountered by respondents who reported less positive experiences. Particular attention is given to recurring issues such as limited guidance, communication barriers, and inconsistencies in the information provided. These insights allow for a more nuanced understanding of how institutional support functions in practice, especially during critical stages of the visa application process.

Finally, the chapter considers the handling of mandatory visa documents by host institutions, offering a more focused perspective on formal administrative responsibilities. By examining both strengths and shortcomings across different aspects of institutional support, this chapter aims to provide a comprehensive overview of how guidance systems impact the overall mobility experience.

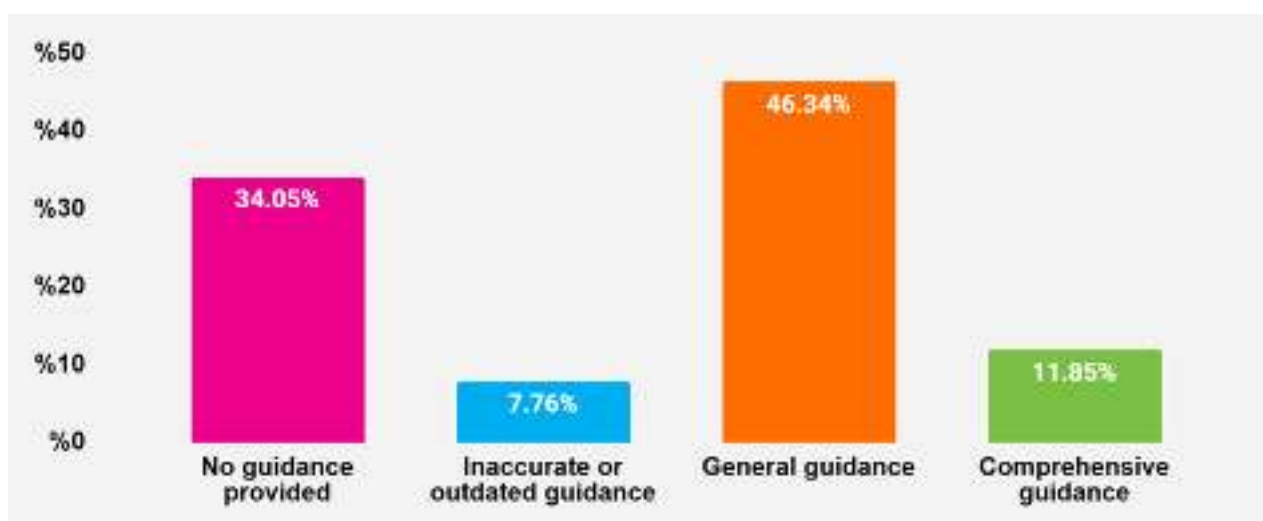
3.1. Quality of Guidance from Sending Institutions

Respondents' assessments of visa-related guidance provided by sending institutions point to a mixed and uneven experience. A total of 34.05% of respondents (158 participants) stated that their sending institution did not provide any visa-related information or support, indicating a significant gap in institutional guidance for a substantial share of participants.

Among those who received some form of support, 46.34% (215 respondents) described it as general in nature, suggesting that institutions often provided only broad or introductory information, while participants were still left to identify the specific visa requirements applicable to their own case.

A smaller proportion, 11.85% (55 respondents), reported receiving comprehensive guidance, indicating that in some cases institutions were able to offer clear, detailed, and up-to-date information adapted to the destination country. At the same time, 7.76% (36 respondents) characterised the guidance they received as inaccurate or outdated, pointing to situations in which institutional input may have contributed to confusion rather than reducing it (Figure 20).

Figure 20



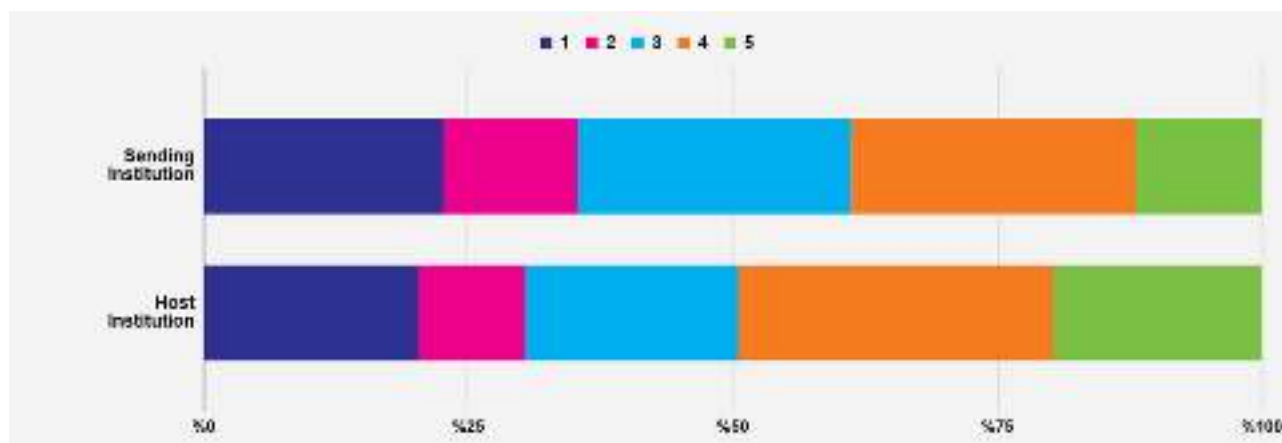
Quality of Visa-Related Guidance Provided by Sending Institutions (N=464)

Overall, this distribution suggests that although many respondents received at least some form of support from their sending institution, the quality, accuracy, and usefulness of that support varied considerably. As a result, a substantial proportion of participants appear to have navigated the visa process with either limited assistance or information that did not fully meet their practical needs.

3.2. Evaluation of Sending & Host Institution Support

When asked to rate the overall information and support provided by their institutions, responses show a broadly similar distribution across the 1–5 scale. In the case of sending institutions, lower ratings of 1 and 2 account for 35.3% (164 respondents), while 25.9% (120) selected 3. On the more positive end, 38.8% (180) rated the support as 4 or 5. For host institutions, 30.4% (153 respondents) gave ratings of 1 or 2, 20.1% (101) selected 3, and 49.5% (249) evaluated the support more positively with ratings of 4 or 5 (Figure 21).

Figure 21



Evaluation of Information and Support from Sending and Host Institutions (N=530)

Although host institution support appears somewhat more positively evaluated overall, the general pattern remains similar across both cases. In both distributions, a substantial share of respondents cluster around the lower and mid-range categories, while the largest combined share falls within the more positive end of the scale. This suggests that, although many participants experienced institutional support as satisfactory or effective, less positive and mixed evaluations also remain highly visible.

Taken together, the findings point to a broadly comparable pattern in the evaluation of institutional support. While host institutions appear to receive slightly more favourable assessments, the overall spread of responses indicates that perceptions of support remain varied, reflecting differences in quality, responsiveness, or clarity across institutional contexts.

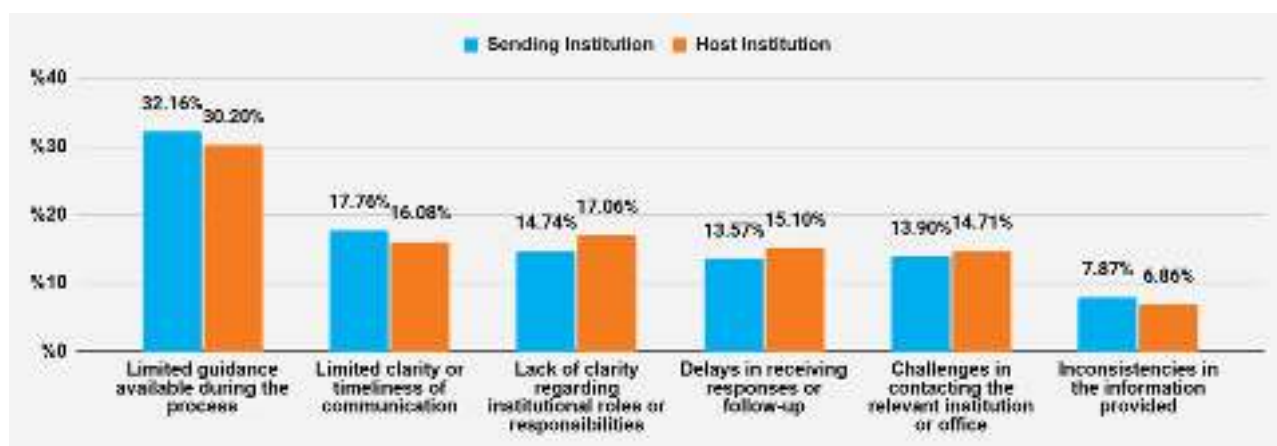
3.3. Issues Encountered with Sending & Host Institution Support

Among respondents who rated institutional support between 1 and 3, a range of recurring issues was identified. In both sending and host institution contexts, the most frequently cited concern was limited guidance during the process, accounting for 32.16% of responses (192) for sending institutions and 30.20% (154) for host institutions.

Other commonly reported issues also follow a broadly similar pattern. For sending institutions, limited clarity or timeliness of communication accounts for 17.76% (106), followed by a lack of clarity regarding institutional roles or responsibilities at 14.74% (88), difficulties in contacting the relevant office at 13.90% (83), delays in receiving responses or follow-up at 13.57% (81), and inconsistencies in the information provided at 7.87% (47).

For host institutions, lack of clarity regarding institutional roles or responsibilities represents 17.06% (87), limited clarity or timeliness of communication 16.08% (82), delays in receiving responses 15.10% (77), difficulties in contacting the relevant office 14.71% (75), and inconsistencies in information 6.86% (35) (Figure 22).

Figure 22



Evaluation of Information and Support from Sending (N=464) and Host Institutions (N=503)

As this follow-up question was directed only to respondents who rated institutional support between 1 and 3, these results provide a more focused picture of the issues associated with less positive or mixed evaluations.

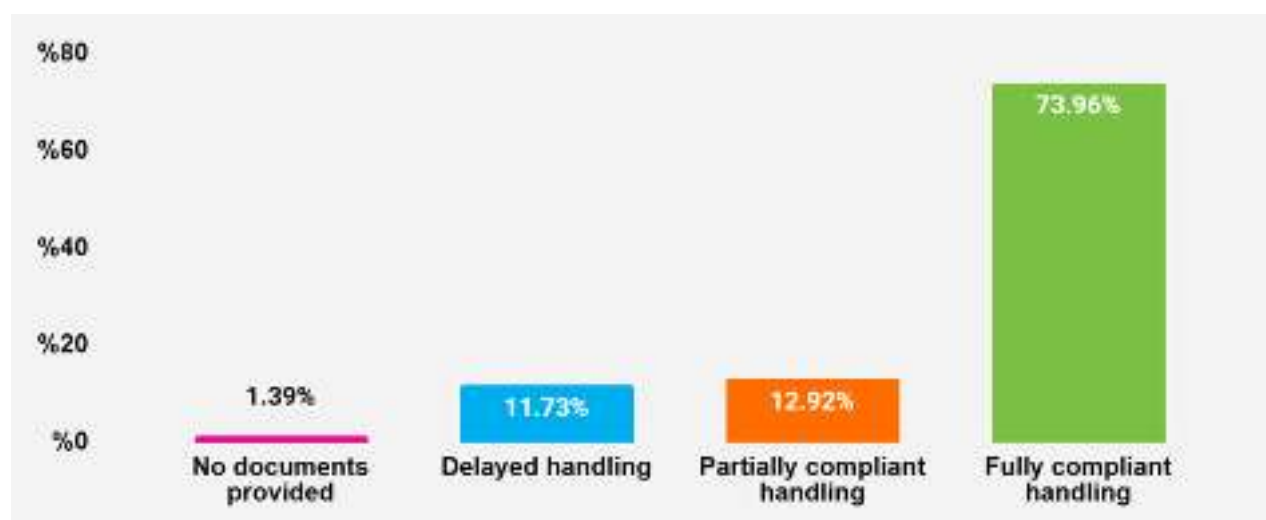
Taken together, the findings suggest that dissatisfaction was shaped not only by the availability of information itself, but also by the way in which support was communicated, maintained, and made accessible throughout the process. Across both institutional contexts, limited guidance, lack of clarity, and communication-related difficulties emerge as recurring themes, suggesting that structural weaknesses in support mechanisms may contribute to uncertainty during time-sensitive stages of the mobility process.

3.4. Handling of Mandatory Visa Documents by Host Institutions

The handling of mandatory visa documents by host institutions is evaluated more positively in comparison to broader support structures. A clear majority of respondents, 73.96% (372), reported fully compliant handling of documents such as acceptance or invitation letters.

At the same time, 12.92% (65) indicated partially compliant handling, and 11.73% (59) experienced delays in receiving the necessary documentation. A very small proportion, 1.39% (7), reported that no documents were provided (Figure 23).

Figure 23



Handling of Mandatory Visa Documents by Host Institutions (N=503)

While the overall picture suggests that most institutions fulfil their formal responsibilities in this area, the presence of delays and partial compliance indicates that, for some respondents, document provision may not always align with the time-sensitive nature of visa procedures. Even relatively limited disruptions at this stage may carry implications for subsequent steps in the application process.



Chapter 4

Embassy & Application Experience



This chapter examines respondents' experiences with embassies and consulates throughout the visa application process, focusing on the practical realities of securing and completing an application. While earlier sections explored institutional guidance and pre-application factors, this chapter shifts attention to the procedural stage itself, where applicants interact directly with official systems, booking platforms, and diplomatic authorities.

The findings presented here highlight the complexity and variability of the application experience. From the choice of application channels to the process of securing an appointment, respondents encountered a system that was often characterised by limited availability, multiple access routes, and varying levels of transparency. In particular, the reliance on digital booking systems as the primary entry point is contrasted with the continued use of alternative channels such as direct communication with embassies, third-party assistance, and premium services.

Beyond access to appointments, the chapter also explores the qualitative dimensions of the process, including communication with consular staff and the clarity of information provided during in-person interactions. These elements play a crucial role in shaping applicants' confidence and ability to navigate requirements effectively. At the same time, challenges related to document submission and additional financial proof requirements reveal the extent to which formal guidelines may differ from actual practice.

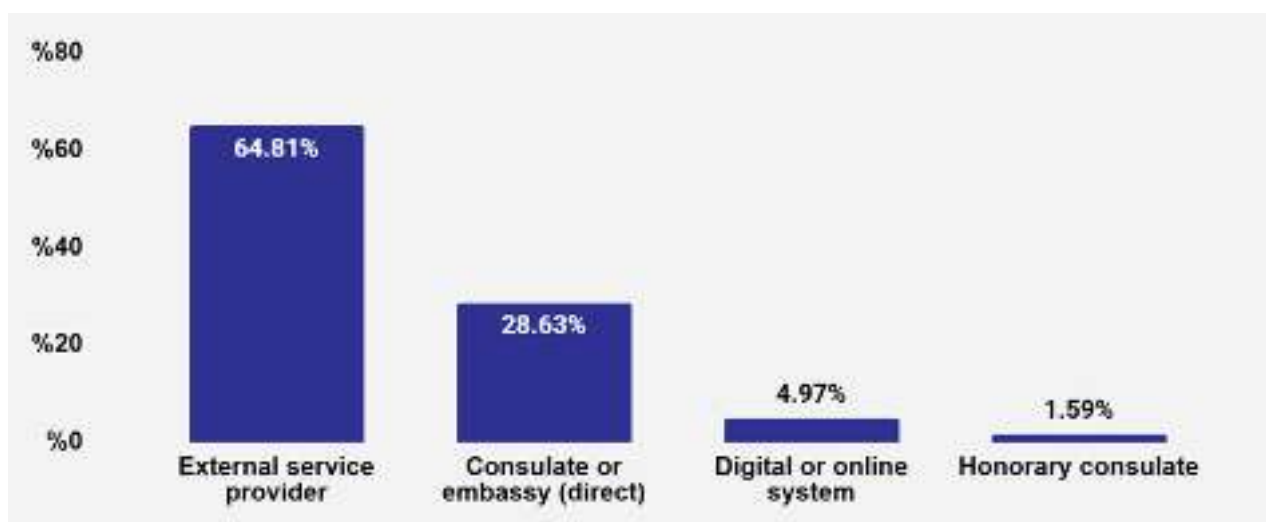
Taken together, this chapter provides a comprehensive overview of the embassy and application phase as a critical stage in the mobility journey. It underscores how procedural barriers, inconsistencies in communication, and financial expectations can influence not only the efficiency of the process but also the overall accessibility of international mobility opportunities.

4.1. Application Channel

The distribution of application channels indicates a strong reliance on intermediary structures in the visa submission process. A clear majority of respondents, 64.81% (326 participants), reported submitting their visa application through an external service provider, suggesting that outsourced visa centres have become the primary interface between applicants and consular authorities. In contrast, 28.63% of respondents (144 participants) applied directly through a consulate or embassy, indicating that direct access to diplomatic institutions remains available but is notably less common. (Figure 24)

Digital or fully online submission systems were used by only 5.0% of respondents (25 participants), highlighting the limited adoption or availability of end-to-end digital visa processing. Meanwhile, a very small proportion, 1.6% (8 participants), relied on honorary consulates, reflecting their relatively minor role in handling visa applications.

Figure 24



Distribution of Visa Application Channels (N= 503)

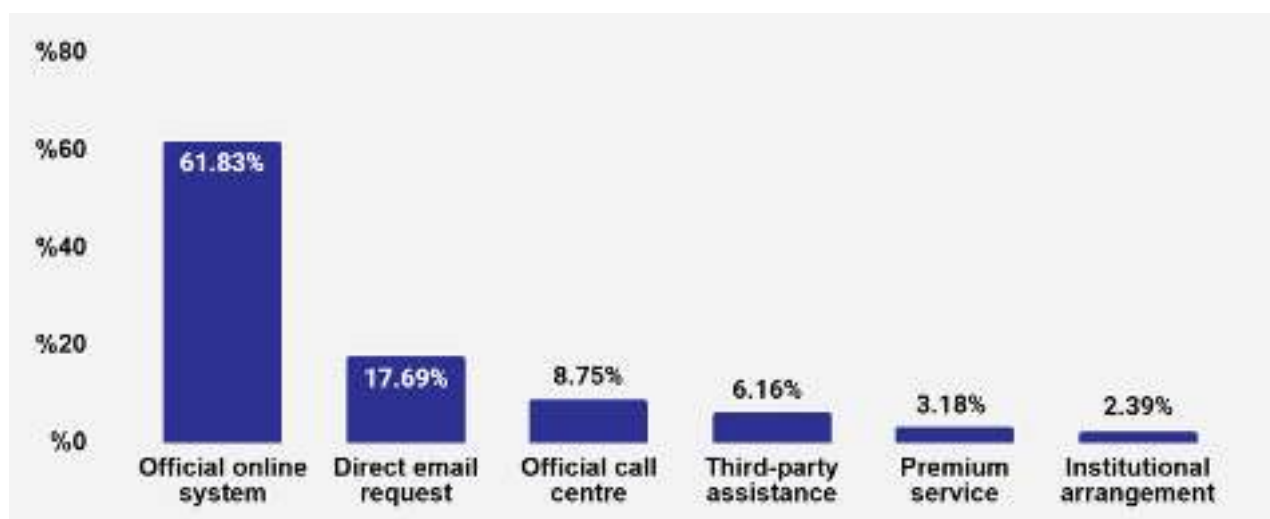
Overall, these findings suggest that the visa application process is predominantly mediated by external service providers rather than being conducted directly with embassies or through digital platforms. This reliance on third-party channels may have implications for accessibility, costs, and the overall transparency of the application process, as applicants are often required to navigate additional layers beyond official diplomatic institutions.

4.2. Appointment Scheduling Channels

The official online system emerged as the primary method for securing visa appointments, with 61.83% of respondents (311 participants) reporting that they booked their appointment through the standard online booking platform. This suggests that digital booking systems constitute the main access point for most applicants (Figure 25).

Other channels were used less frequently but remain relevant. A total of 17.69% of respondents (89 participants) obtained their appointment through direct email correspondence with the consulate or embassy, while 8.75% (44 participants) relied on the official telephone service. In addition, 6.16% (31 participants) reported using third-party assistance. Smaller shares of respondents secured appointments through premium services offered by the visa centre for an additional fee (3.18%, 16 participants) or through arrangements made by a university or another organisation (2.39%, 12 participants).

Figure 25



Distribution of Visa Appointment Booking Methods (N=503)

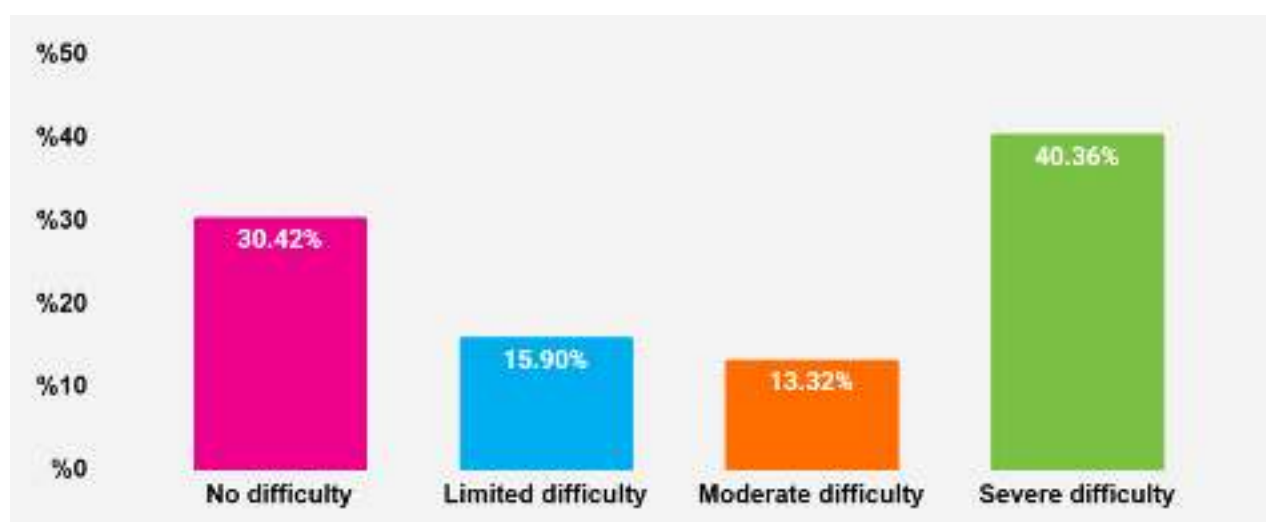
Overall, while the standard online booking platform appears to be the dominant channel, the presence of multiple alternative routes suggests that not all applicants relied exclusively on the primary system. Instead, some appear to have turned to direct contact, institutional support, or paid options in order to secure access to an appointment.

4.3. Difficulty of Securing an Appointment

Securing a visa appointment appears to be a significant challenge within the application process. While 30.42% of respondents (153 participants) reported no difficulty, indicating that they were able to obtain an appointment immediately, this was not the experience for most applicants. A further 15.90% (80 participants) described the process as involving limited difficulty, suggesting that an appointment was secured only after a few attempts.

At the same time, 13.32% of respondents (67 participants) reported a moderate level of difficulty, pointing to the need for repeated attempts over a longer period. Most notably, the largest share, 40.36% (203 participants), experienced severe difficulty, indicating that securing an appointment required extensive effort over a prolonged period of time (Figure 26).

Figure 26



Level of Difficulty in Securing a Visa Appointment (N=503)

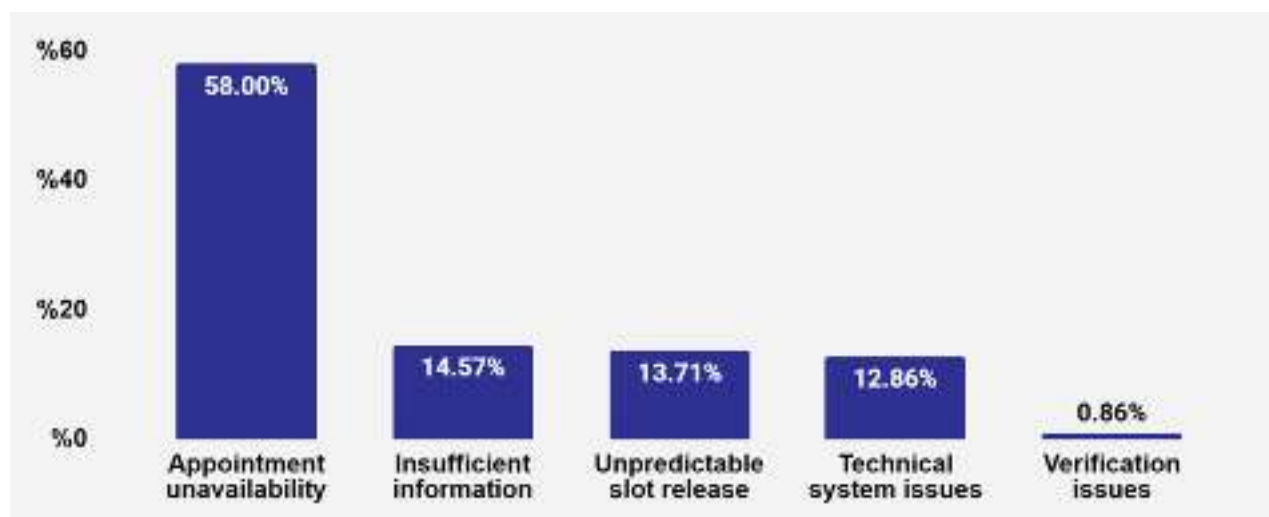
Overall, this distribution suggests a highly uneven pattern of access. Although some respondents were able to obtain appointments without substantial obstacles, a larger proportion faced repeated or prolonged difficulties, indicating that appointment availability may be inconsistent and burdensome for many applicants.

4.4. Barriers in Appointment Scheduling

Among respondents who experienced difficulties in securing a visa appointment, the most frequently reported barrier was the consistent unavailability of appointment slots, cited by 58.0% (203 respondents). This suggests that, for many applicants, the main challenge lay in the simple absence of available booking opportunities rather than in the formal steps of the process itself.

Other reported difficulties included unclear information regarding appointment availability or procedures (14.57%, 51 respondents), irregular or unexpected release of appointment slots (13.71%, 48 respondents), and technical problems within the booking system such as errors or instability (12.86%, 45 respondents). Issues related to email or SMS verification were reported only rarely, accounting for 0.86% of responses (3 respondents) (Figure 27).

Figure 27



Reported Barriers in Securing Visa Appointments (N=350)

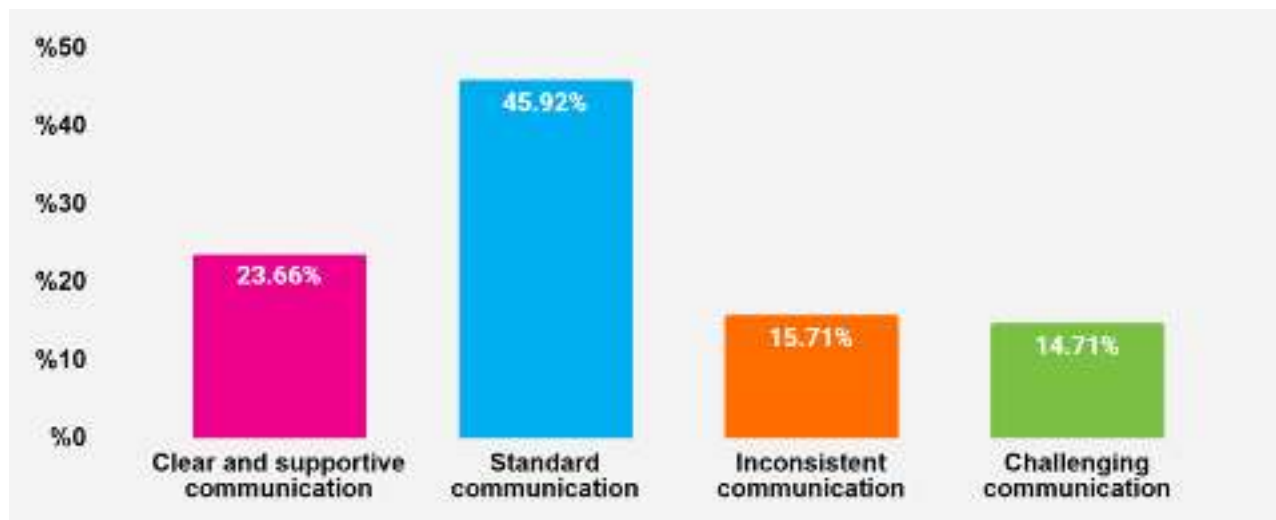
Taken together, these findings indicate that the central barrier was often access to the appointment system rather than the procedural requirements alone. In particular, the prominence of slot unavailability, unclear information, and irregular release patterns suggests that many applicants had to deal with a process marked by uncertainty, repeated checking, and limited predictability.

4.5. Communication During Appointment

In terms of communication with staff during the appointment, 45.92% of respondents (231 participants) described the interaction as standard, suggesting that communication was largely procedural but sufficient for completing the appointment. A further 23.66% (119 participants) reported clear and supportive communication, indicating that staff provided explanations and guidance in a way that helped applicants navigate the process more confidently.

At the same time, 15.71% of respondents (79 participants) experienced inconsistent communication, pointing to situations in which the information provided during the appointment differed from what was indicated in official guidance. In addition, 14.71% (74 participants) described communication as challenging, suggesting that language barriers or unclear instructions made the interaction more difficult to follow (Figure 28).

Figure 28



Quality of Communication During Visa Appointments (N=503)

Overall, while most respondents appear to have encountered communication that was at least functional, the proportion reporting inconsistency or difficulty remains substantial. This suggests that communication during appointments did not always provide the same level of clarity or reassurance, and that for a notable group of applicants, interaction with staff may have introduced additional uncertainty rather than reducing it.

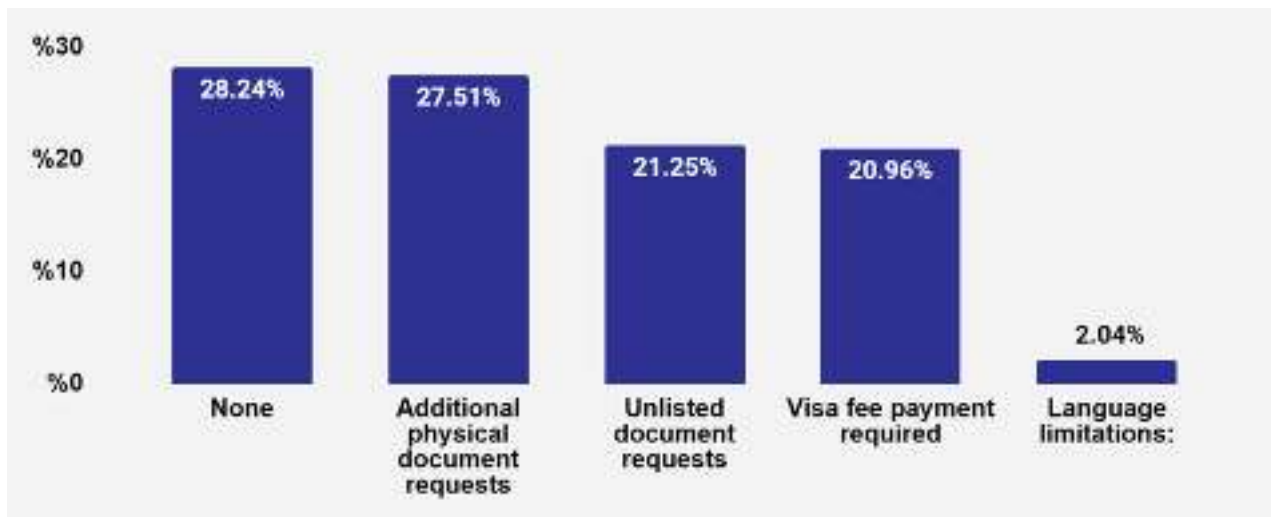
4.6. Document Submission Challenges

In terms of document submission experiences, 28.24% of respondents (194 participants) reported no issues, indicating that the process was completed in line with official requirements without additional complications. However, a substantial proportion of respondents encountered procedural difficulties during this stage.

A further 27.51% (189 participants) reported additional physical document requests, suggesting that applicants were frequently required to provide supplementary paperwork beyond the standard submission requirements. Similarly, 21.25% (146 participants) indicated unlisted document requests, pointing to inconsistencies between official documentation checklists and actual embassy or consulate practices.

In addition, 20.96% of respondents (144 participants) reported being required to pay the visa fee despite presenting documentation that would typically support exemption eligibility, highlighting potential variability in the application of fee-related procedures. Language limitations were reported by 2.04% (14 participants), indicating that communication barriers played a relatively minor role compared to documentation and procedural issues (Figure 29).

Figure 29



Distribution of Document Submission Challenges (N=503)

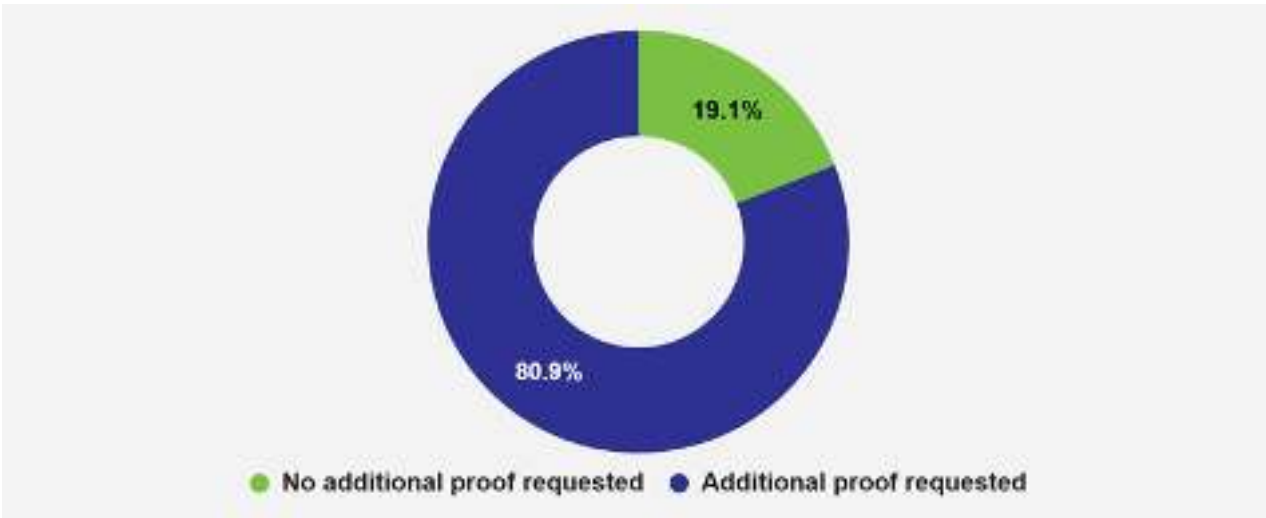
Overall, while some respondents experienced a smooth document submission process, the majority faced additional requirements such as extra physical documents, unlisted requests, and unexpected visa fee payments. These findings suggest inconsistencies between official guidelines and actual practice, leading to reduced clarity and predictability for applicants. Language limitations were relatively rare compared to other issues.

4.7. Financial Proof Requirements

A substantial majority of respondents (80.9%, 407) were asked to provide financial proof beyond what was officially covered by their programme or grant, while 19.1% (96) were not (Figure 30).

This indicates that, for most participants, formal programme funding alone was not considered sufficient to meet visa requirements. Instead, applicants were often expected to demonstrate additional financial capacity, extending beyond the baseline support structures associated with their mobility programme.

Figure 30



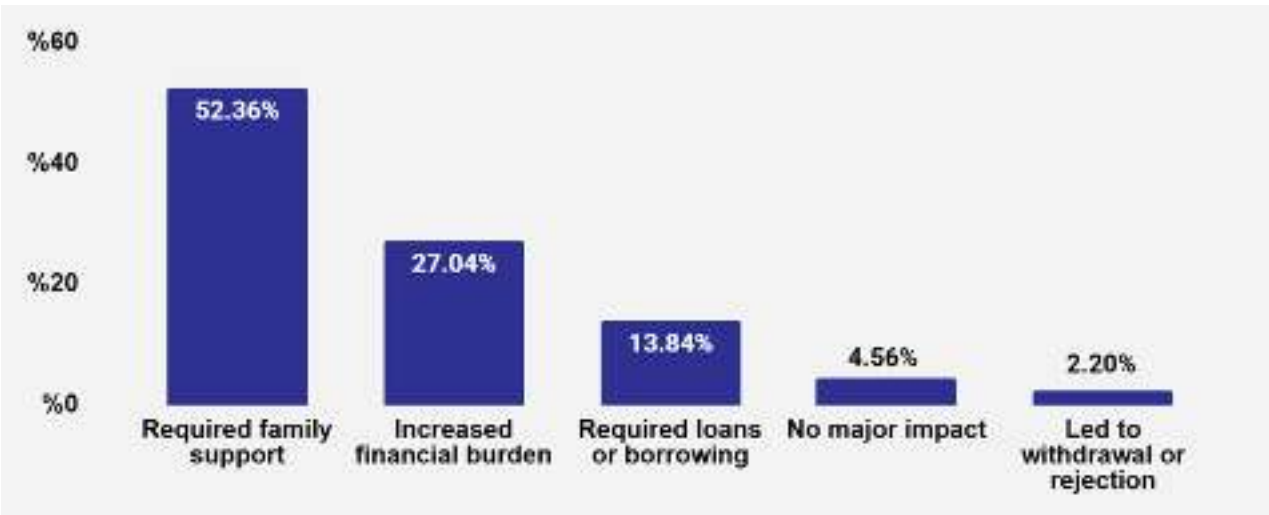
Additional Financial Proof Requirements (N=503)

4.8. Impact of Additional Financial Requirements

Among those affected by additional financial proof requirements, the most common outcome was reliance on family support, reported by 52.36% (333 responses). 27.04% (172) indicated an increased financial burden, while 13.84% (88) required loans or borrowing. A smaller proportion (4.56%, 29) reported no major impact, and 2.20% (14) indicated that the requirement contributed to withdrawal from or inability to proceed with the mobility (Figure 31).

These findings suggest that additional financial requirements were often absorbed through personal or family resources rather than institutional support mechanisms. While only a limited number of respondents reported that such requirements directly prevented participation, the broader distribution points to a shift in financial responsibility towards individuals, which may shape both accessibility and the overall experience of mobility in less visible ways.

Figure 31



Impact of Additional Financial Requirements on Respondents (N=503)



Chapter 5

Visa Processing Time & Costs

This chapter examines the procedural timelines and financial dimensions of visa applications within the context of international mobility. Building on the previous sections, it focuses on two interrelated aspects of the visa process: the duration of visa processing and issuance, and the associated financial consequences experienced by applicants.

The analysis first explores visa processing times, including the period between application submission and final decision, as well as the timing of visa issuance in relation to intended travel dates. These indicators provide insight into the predictability and efficiency of visa procedures, highlighting variations in administrative timelines and their implications for applicants' planning capacity.

Subsequently, the chapter addresses the impact of these timelines on travel and accommodation arrangements, illustrating how delays or compressed processing periods can influence logistical decisions, financial commitments, and overall mobility planning. It then turns to the structure of visa-related costs, distinguishing between official fees, additional service charges, and indirect expenses such as documentation, insurance, and intermediary services.

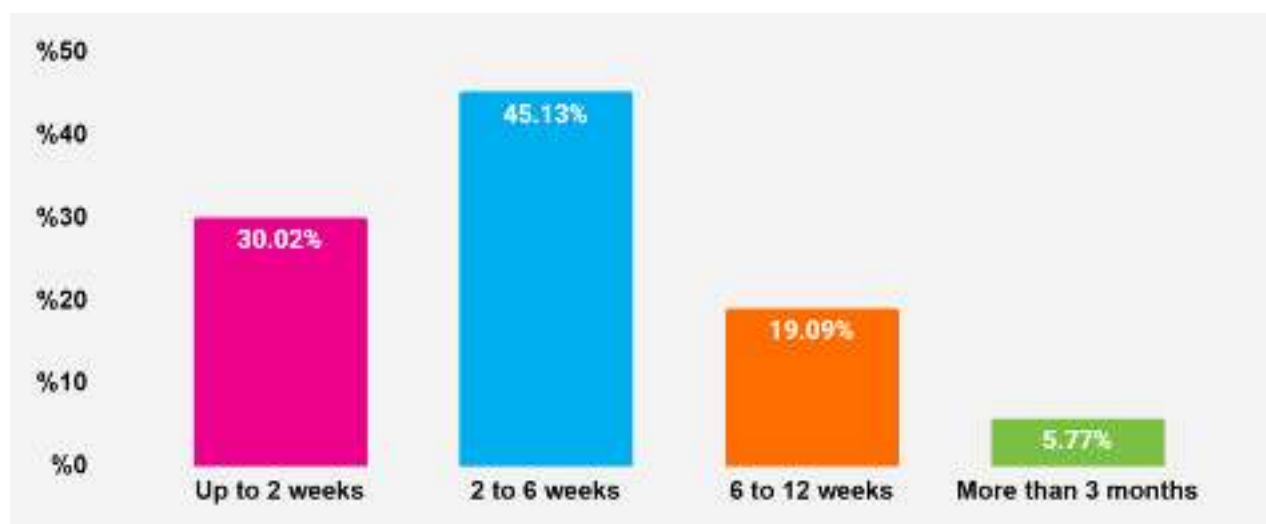
Finally, the chapter examines non-refundable financial losses linked to visa delays or rejections. This section sheds light on the extent to which applicants are exposed to financial risk during the visa process, particularly when arrangements are made prior to final visa confirmation.

Overall, the findings presented in this chapter highlight that while many applicants experience relatively manageable processing times and limited financial disruption, a significant proportion face uncertainties and costs that may affect both the timing and affordability of international mobility.

5.1. Visa Processing Time

The duration between submission of a complete visa application and the final decision shows a concentration within mid-range processing periods. The smallest share of respondents, 5.77% (29 respondents), reported waiting more than three months. This is followed by 19.09% (96 respondents) who experienced processing times of 6 to 12 weeks. A larger proportion, 30.02% (151 respondents), received a decision within up to 2 weeks. The highest share, 45.13% (227 respondents), reported waiting between 2 to 6 weeks. (Figure 32).

Figure 32



Distribution of Visa Processing Times (N=503)

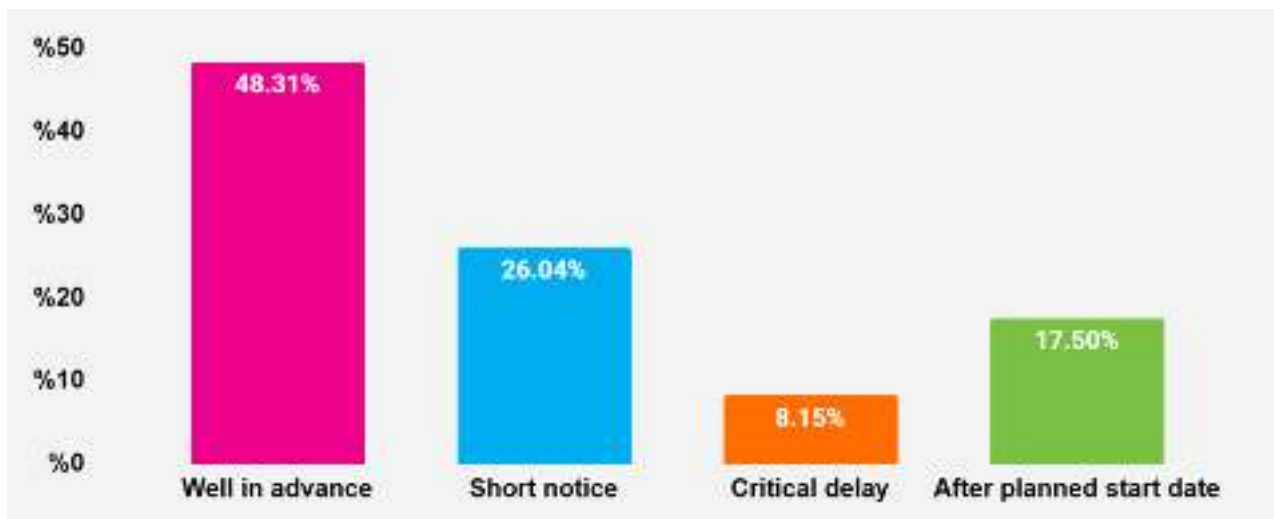
Overall, while a majority of applications were processed within a relatively moderate timeframe, a non-negligible share of respondents experienced extended processing periods. These longer durations may reflect variations in consular workload, case complexity, or seasonal demand, contributing to a less uniform processing experience across applicants.

5.2. Timing of Visa Delivery Relative to Departure

When considering the timing of visa issuance in relation to travel dates, the largest share of respondents (48.3%, 243) received their visa well in advance, followed by 26.0% (131) who received it on short notice. A smaller proportion, 17.5% (88), reported receiving their visa after their planned start date, while 8.1% (41) experienced a critical delay, receiving it less than 48 hours before departure (Figure 33).

These figures suggest that while nearly half of respondents were able to proceed with adequate lead time, a substantial proportion experienced compressed timelines. In such cases, the proximity of visa issuance to departure may have limited the ability to plan travel logistics with certainty and increased reliance on flexible or last-minute arrangements.

Figure 33

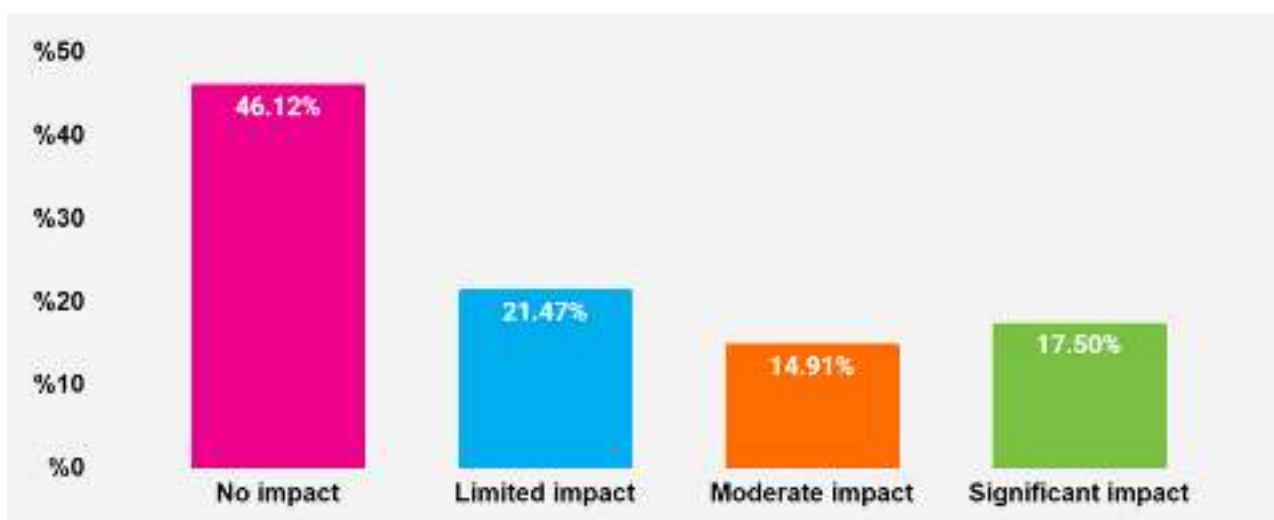


Timing of Visa Issuance Relative to Departure Date (N=503)

5.3. Impact on Travel and Accommodation Arrangements

Visa processing timelines had varying degrees of impact on respondents' travel and accommodation plans. 46.12% (232) reported no impact, indicating that their arrangements proceeded as initially planned. Limited impact was reported by 21.47% (108), involving minor adjustments such as rescheduling. A further 14.91% (75) experienced moderate impact, requiring changes to bookings alongside additional costs, while 17.50% (88) reported significant impact, including cancellations and substantial financial losses (Figure 34).

Figure 34



Impact of Visa Processing Times on Travel and Accommodation Arrangements (N=503)

The distribution indicates that while a portion of respondents were able to maintain their original plans, a considerable share had to adapt their arrangements in response to visa-related timing. These adjustments appear to range from minor logistical changes to more disruptive outcomes involving financial and organisational consequences.

5.4. Visa Application Fee Structure

The structure of visa-related fees shows variation across respondents. 37.57% (189) reported being subject to both official visa fees and additional service or administrative fees. 29.22% (147) paid only the official visa fee, while 19.68% (99) paid only service fee in cases where the official visa fee itself was waived. A smaller proportion, 13.52% (68), reported that neither official nor additional fees were charged (Figure 35).

Figure 35



Distribution of Visa Fee Structures (N=503)

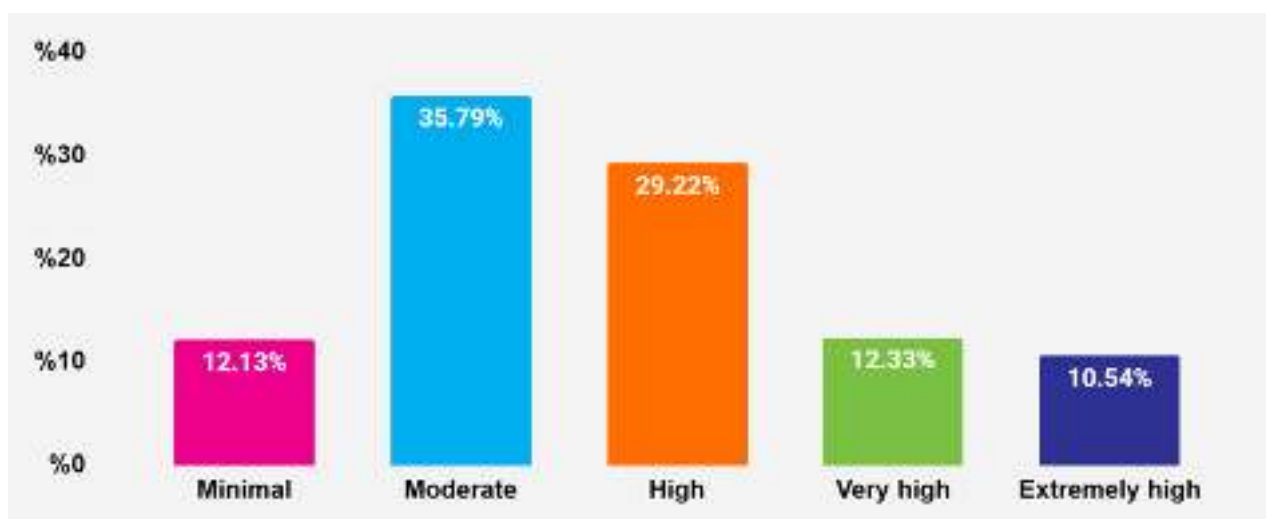
This distribution suggests that, beyond the standard official fee, additional intermediary or administrative costs are relatively common. The coexistence of different fee structures points to a layered cost environment, where the total financial burden may depend not only on formal requirements but also on the processing channel used.

5.5. Indirect Costs of the Visa Application

Indirect costs associated with the visa application process vary across respondents, with a distribution ranging from low to very high expenses. A small share of respondents reported minimal costs below €50 (12.13%, 61), followed by those reporting moderate costs between €50 and €150 (35.79%, 180). Higher cost categories include high costs between €150 and €300 (29.22%, 147), very high costs between €300 and €500 (12.33%, 62), and extremely high costs exceeding €500 (10.54%, 53) (Figure 36).

These figures suggest that indirect expenses—such as travel to consulates, documentation, insurance, translations, or intermediary services—constitute a significant component of the overall visa-related financial burden. For a considerable proportion of respondents, these costs extend well beyond the official visa fee itself.

Figure 36

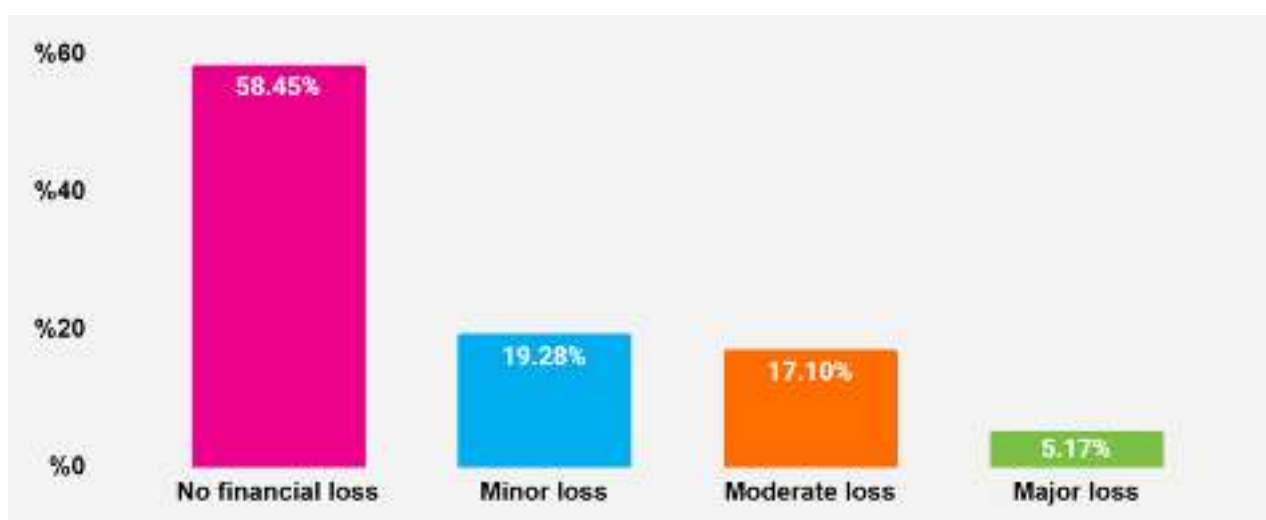


Indirect Costs Associated with Visa Applications (N=503)

5.6. Non-Refundable Financial Losses

In terms of non-refundable financial losses linked to visa delays or rejections, the majority of respondents (58.45%, 294) reported no losses. Among those who did incur losses, 19.28% (97) experienced minor losses under €100, 17.10% (86) reported moderate losses between €100 and €500, and 5.17% (26) faced major losses exceeding €500 (Figure 37).

Figure 37



Non-Refundable Financial Losses Linked to Visa Delays or Rejections (N=503)

While most respondents did not encounter direct financial loss in this regard, the presence of moderate to major losses among a subset of participants highlights the potential financial risks associated with timing uncertainties and visa outcomes. These losses may stem from non-refundable bookings, administrative costs, or other commitments made prior to visa confirmation.



Chapter 6

Visa Rejection



Visa rejection represents a critical but relatively infrequent stage within the overall mobility process. While the vast majority of respondents successfully obtained their visas without experiencing a refusal, a small proportion reported at least one rejection before eventual approval. Although limited in scale, these cases are analytically significant, as they highlight additional procedural barriers that some applicants face before completing their mobility journey.

This chapter examines the incidence and nature of visa refusals among respondents, as well as the experiences that follow a rejection. It first outlines the prevalence of visa refusal within the sample, before exploring the types of support accessed after a refusal occurs. The analysis then turns to the distribution of support sources, highlighting the role of sending institutions, host institutions, consulates, and external service providers, alongside a notable share of respondents who reported receiving no support at all.

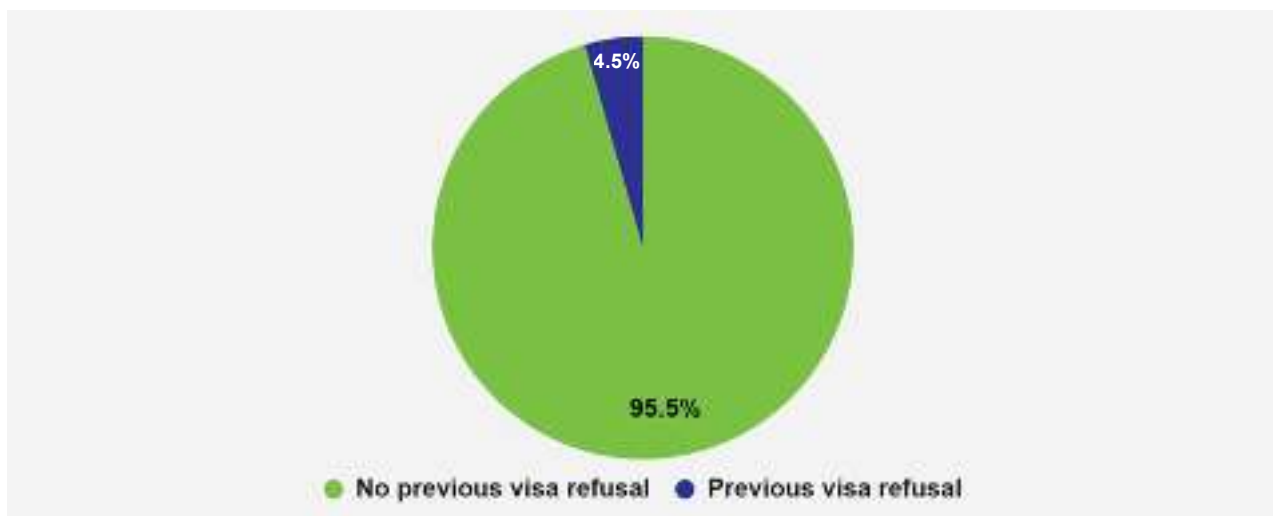
Finally, the chapter reviews the officially stated reasons for visa refusals, identifying the most common grounds cited in refusal notices. By combining these dimensions, the chapter aims to provide a comprehensive overview of visa rejection as both an administrative outcome and a lived experience within the broader context of international mobility.

6.1. Visa Refusal Experience

Among respondents who proceeded through the visa application process, the vast majority did not experience a refusal prior to approval. 95.50% (448 respondents) reported no visa refusal, while 4.50% (21) indicated that they had received at least one refusal before ultimately obtaining a visa (Figure 38).

Although refusals affect a relatively small proportion of the overall sample, their presence highlights a subset of applicants whose mobility trajectory involved additional procedural steps before successful completion of the process.

Figure 38



Distribution of Visa Refusal Experience Among Respondents (N=469)

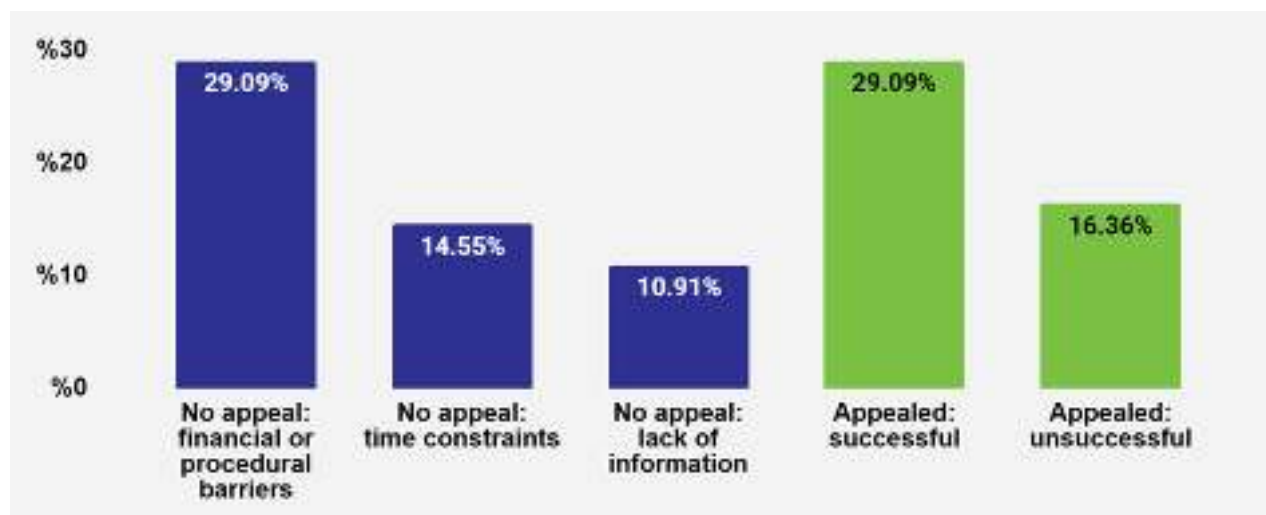
6.2. Response to Visa Refusal

Among respondents who experienced a visa refusal, responses regarding subsequent action show a mixed pattern of engagement with formal review mechanisms. Just under one third of respondents (29.09%, 16 individuals) reported that they did not submit an appeal due to financial or procedural barriers, indicating that resource constraints may have limited their ability to challenge the decision. A further 14.55% (8 respondents) did not appeal due to time constraints, while 10.91% (6 respondents) cited a lack of information about the appeal process, highlighting informational gaps as an additional barrier to procedural follow-up.

In contrast, a notable share of respondents engaged with the appeal process. 29.09% (16 respondents) reported submitting an appeal that was ultimately successful, suggesting that formal review mechanisms can be effective for a significant proportion of those who pursue them. Meanwhile, 16.36% (9 respondents) indicated that they appealed but did not succeed. (Figure 39)

Overall, the findings suggest that while appeal mechanisms are accessible and can lead to positive outcomes, a substantial proportion of applicants either do not pursue appeals or are constrained by structural and informational barriers that prevent further action following a refusal.

Figure 39

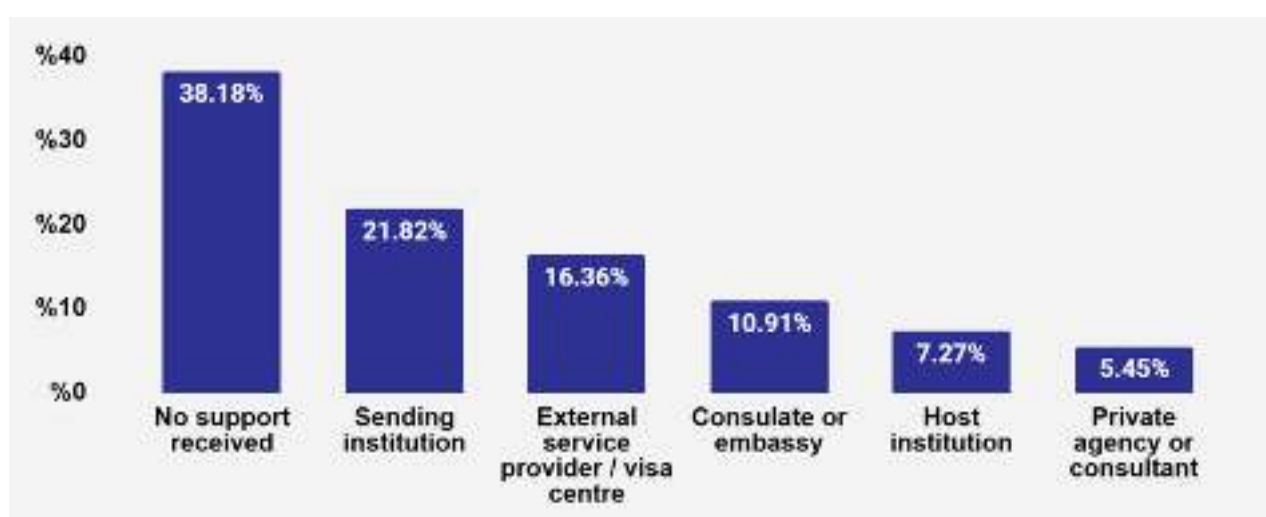


Distribution of Responses to Visa Refusal (N=55)

6.3. Sources of Support Following Refusal

Support following a visa refusal was not consistently reported across respondents. 38.18% (21) indicated that they did not receive any support or information from institutions or organisations. Among those who did receive support, the sending institution was the most frequently cited source (21.82%, 12), followed by external service providers or visa centres (16.36%, 9), consulates or embassies (10.91%, 6), and host institutions (7.27%, 4). A smaller proportion (5.45%, 3) relied on private agencies or consultants for assistance (Figure 40).

Figure 40



Sources of Support Following Visa Refusal (N=55)

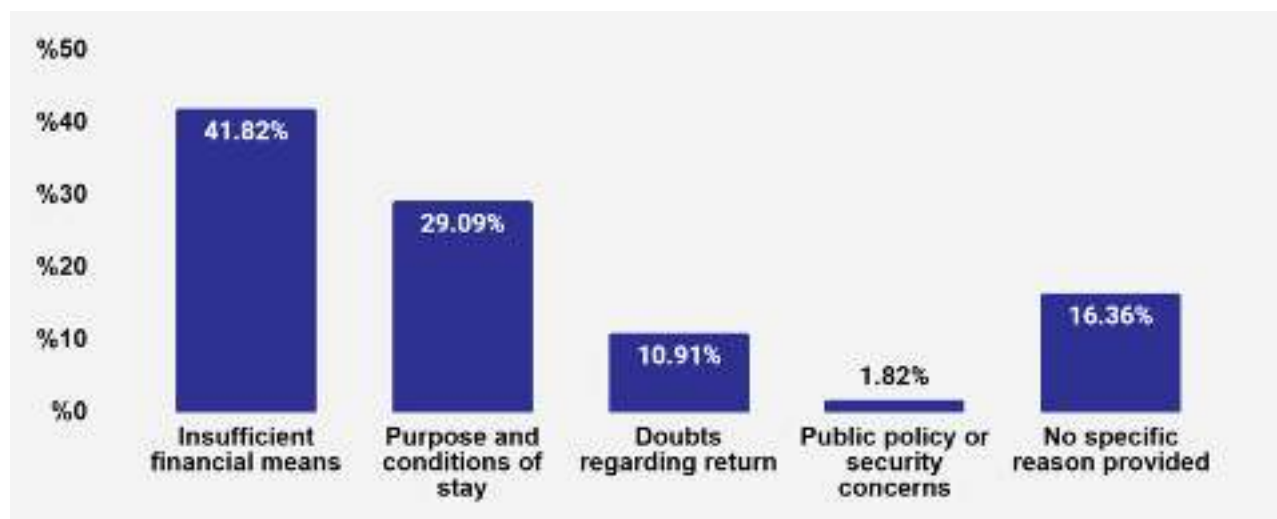
The distribution suggests that institutional support is present but not uniformly experienced. In cases where no support was received, respondents may have navigated the post-refusal process independently, whereas others drew on a combination of formal and informal channels to seek guidance.

6.4. Stated Reasons for Visa Refusal

According to the official refusal notices, the most frequently cited reason for visa refusal was insufficient financial means, reported by 41.82% (23 respondents). This was followed by concerns related to the purpose and conditions of stay (29.09%, 16 respondents). Doubts regarding the applicant's intention to return to their home country were cited in 10.91% (6 respondents) of cases, while public policy or security concerns were rarely mentioned, accounting for only 1.82% (1 respondent). In 16.36% (9 respondents) of cases, no specific or individualised reason was provided in the refusal notice.

Overall, the findings indicate that financial documentation and the perceived clarity of the intended stay are the primary determinants of refusal outcomes in this sample. At the same time, the presence of cases without detailed justification suggests variability in the transparency of refusal communications, which may limit applicants' ability to fully understand the grounds for the decision.

Figure 41



Distribution of Visa Refusal Reasons (N=55)



Chapter 7

Impact on Experience & Wellbeing



This chapter explores how visa-related procedures influence participants' overall mobility experience, with a particular focus on both experiential and psychological dimensions. While previous sections examined structural and administrative aspects of the application process, this chapter shifts the focus towards how these processes are perceived and internalised by respondents once their mobility has begun.

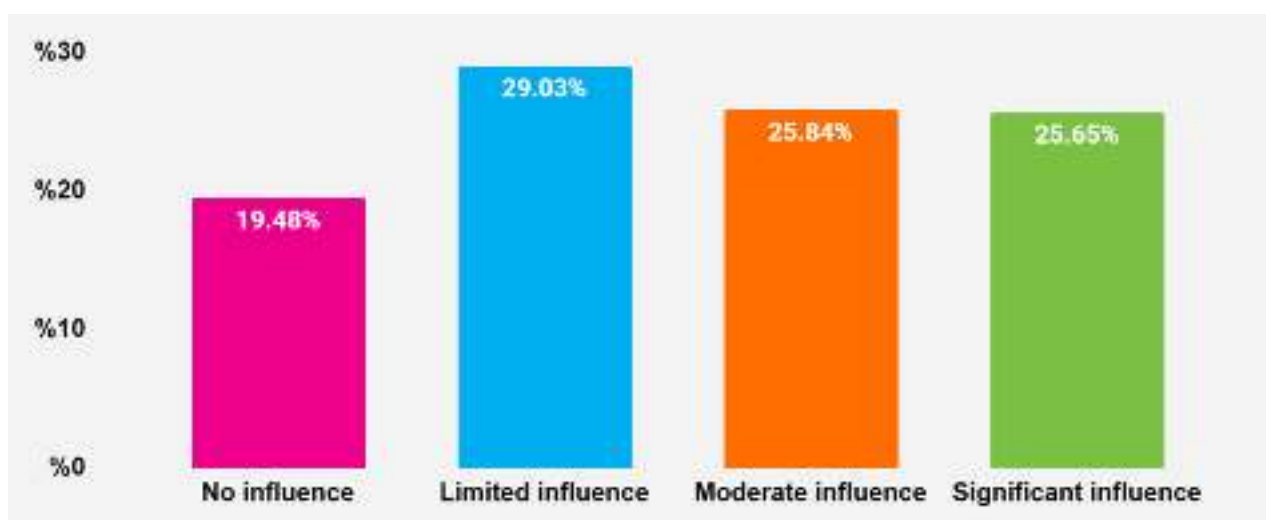
The findings highlight that visa procedures extend beyond logistical considerations, shaping not only access to mobility but also the quality of participation, sense of inclusion, and overall satisfaction with the programme. Delays, uncertainty, and administrative complexity emerge as factors that can disrupt early stages of mobility, affect engagement with academic and social components, and contribute to varying levels of stress and reduced wellbeing.

By analysing the extent to which visa-related challenges influence overall perceptions, missed opportunities, academic focus, and feelings of equal treatment, this chapter provides a comprehensive understanding of how administrative barriers translate into lived experiences. It thereby underscores the broader implications of visa processes for both individual outcomes and the inclusiveness of international mobility programmes.

7.1. Overall Perception of the Mobility Programme

The visa application process appears to have played a notable role in shaping respondents' overall perception of their mobility experience. 19.48% (98 respondents) reported no influence, while 29.03% (146) described the process as inconvenient but without lasting effects. At the same time, a substantial share indicated deeper levels of impact, with 25.84% (130) reporting moderate influence that affected their ability to fully engage, and 25.65% (129) reporting a significant negative influence on their overall perception of the programme (Figure 42).

Figure 42



Distribution of the Impact of the Visa Application Process on Overall Mobility Experience (N=503)

Taken together, the findings suggest that while some respondents separated visa-related challenges from their overall experience, for a considerable group the administrative process shaped how mobility was evaluated. Overall, more respondents reported some influence than none.

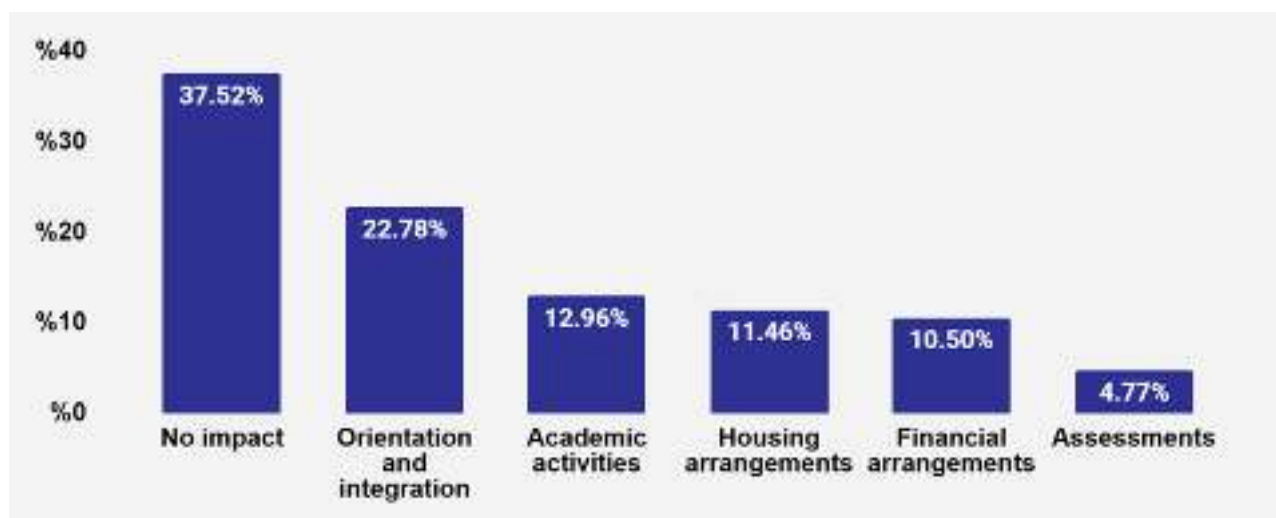
7.2. Missed Components Due to Visa Delays

Responses indicate that visa-related delays affected a substantial share of participants, although experiences were mixed. While the largest group of responses, 37.52% (275), reported no missed components, a considerable proportion experienced disruptions across different areas of their mobility. Orientation and integration activities were the most frequently affected, accounting for 22.78% of responses (167), suggesting that delays primarily disrupted the initial phase of adjustment and social inclusion. Academic activities such as lectures and classes were impacted in 12.96% of cases (95), indicating that delays could extend into core educational participation. (Figure 43)

Practical aspects of mobility were likewise influenced, with housing arrangements reported in 11.46% of responses (84) and financial processes, including grant-related matters, in 10.5% (77). These findings point to challenges in settling in and accessing essential resources upon arrival. A smaller but still notable share, 4.77% (35), reported missing assessments, which may have direct academic consequences.

Overall, the distribution suggests that while many participants were not affected, visa delays had tangible consequences for a significant proportion, particularly in the early and organisational stages of the mobility experience, with some effects extending into academic and administrative domains.

Figure 43



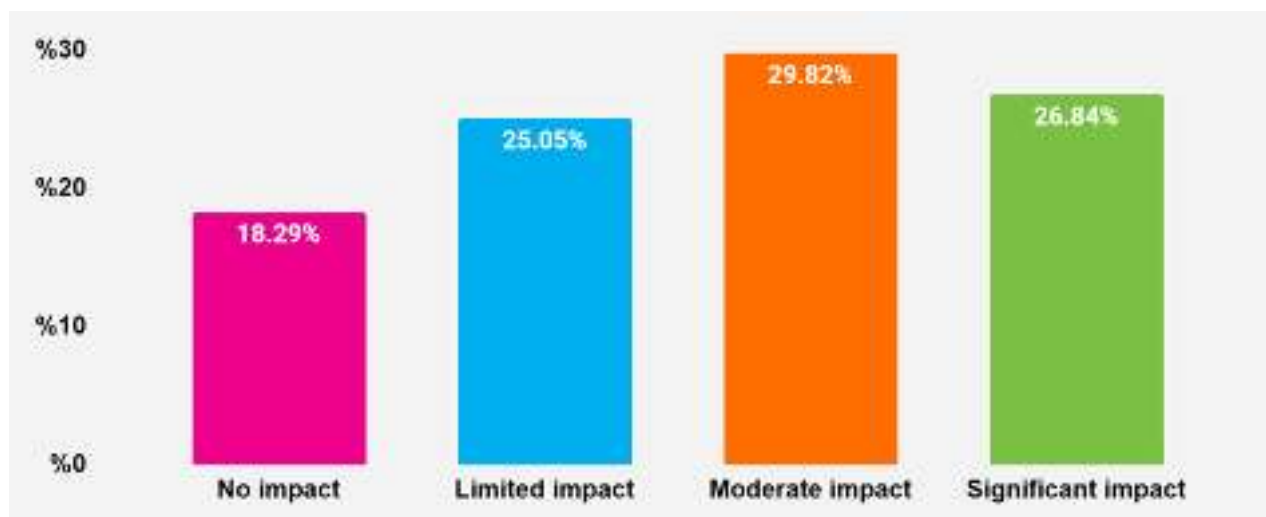
Distribution of Missed Mobility Components Due to Visa Delays (N=503)

7.3. Wellbeing and Academic Focus

Visa-related uncertainty had varying degrees of impact on respondents' wellbeing and academic focus. 18.29% (92) reported no impact, while 25.05% (126) experienced limited impact, characterised by temporary stress without major consequences. A further 29.82% (150) reported moderate impact, including reduced concentration or increased stress, and 26.84% (135) indicated significant impact affecting their wellbeing or academic engagement (Figure 44).

These findings indicate that the visa process is not only a logistical or administrative concern but may also function as a source of psychological strain for a considerable proportion of respondents. While experiences differ, the combined share of moderate and significant impact suggests that uncertainty during the visa process can extend into academic performance and overall wellbeing for many applicants.

Figure 44



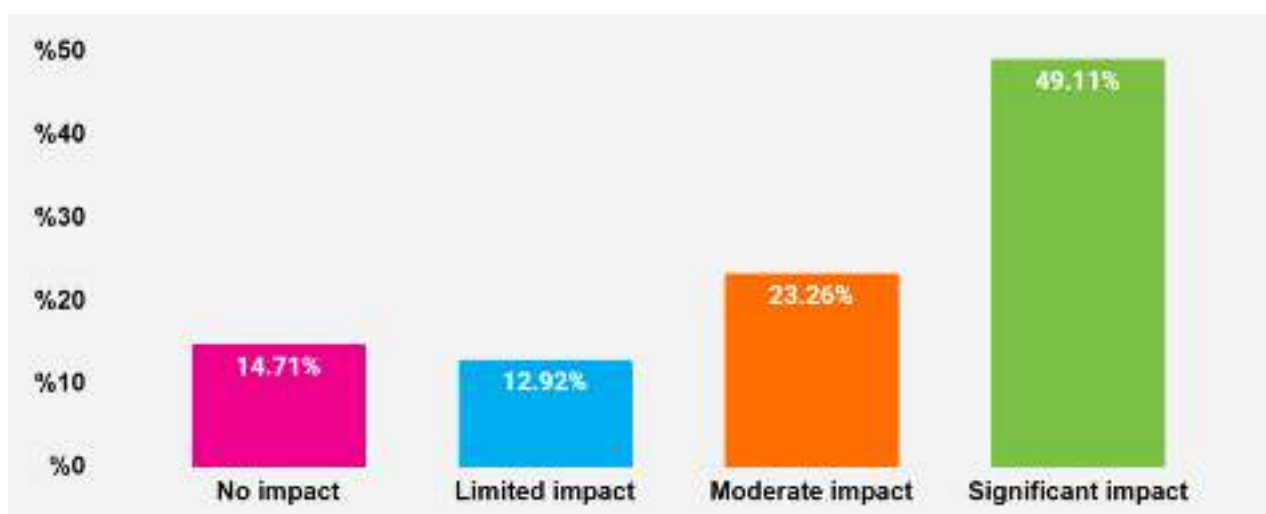
Impact of Visa-Related Uncertainty on Wellbeing and Academic Focus (N=503)

7.4. Perception of Equal Treatment

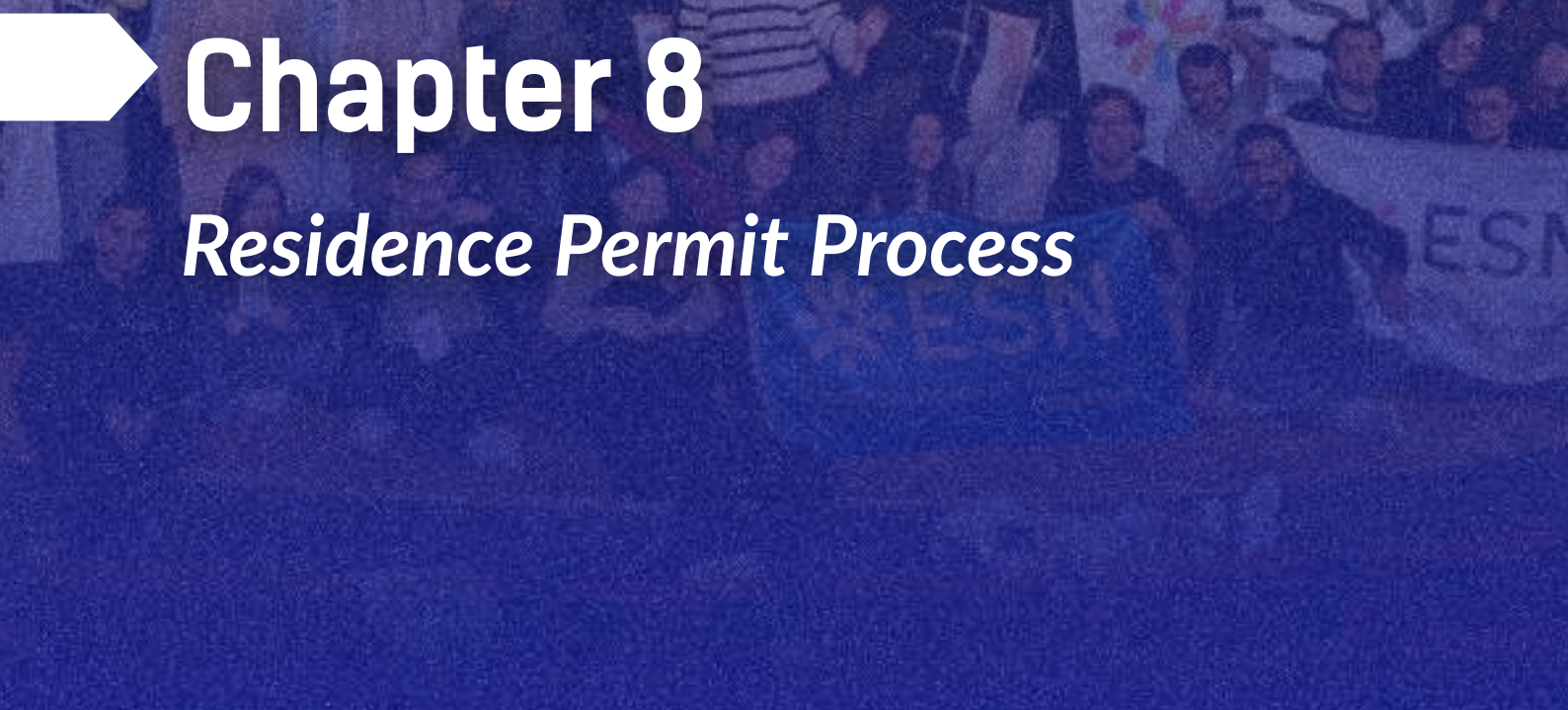
Respondents' perceptions of equal treatment compared to peers from other countries show a pronounced shift towards experiences of disadvantage. 14.71% (74) reported no impact on their perception of equality, while 12.92% (65) felt somewhat disadvantaged. A larger proportion indicated moderate impact (23.26%, 117), and the most frequently selected response was significant impact, reported by 49.11% (247) of respondents, reflecting a perception of systematic disadvantage due to visa-related procedures (Figure 45).

These responses suggest that visa requirements are not only administrative in nature but are also closely linked to perceptions of fairness within mobility programmes. For many respondents, differences in administrative burden appear to translate into broader reflections on equal access and treatment, particularly when compared to peers who may not face similar procedural requirements.

Figure 45



Impact of Visa Procedures on Perceived Equal Treatment (N=503)



Chapter 8

Residence Permit Process



Following arrival in the host country, the residence permit or registration process represents a critical phase in participants' mobility experience, shaping their legal status, access to services, and overall integration. While obtaining a visa enables initial entry, the transition to a valid residence status often involves additional administrative procedures that must be completed within a limited timeframe. These processes vary significantly across countries in terms of requirements, timelines, and institutional involvement.

This chapter examines respondents' experiences with residence permit and registration procedures after arrival, focusing on the level of support provided by host institutions, access to appointments, and the continuity of legal status. It also explores the types of challenges encountered during the application process, as well as the broader impact of administrative delays on participants' rights and mobility.

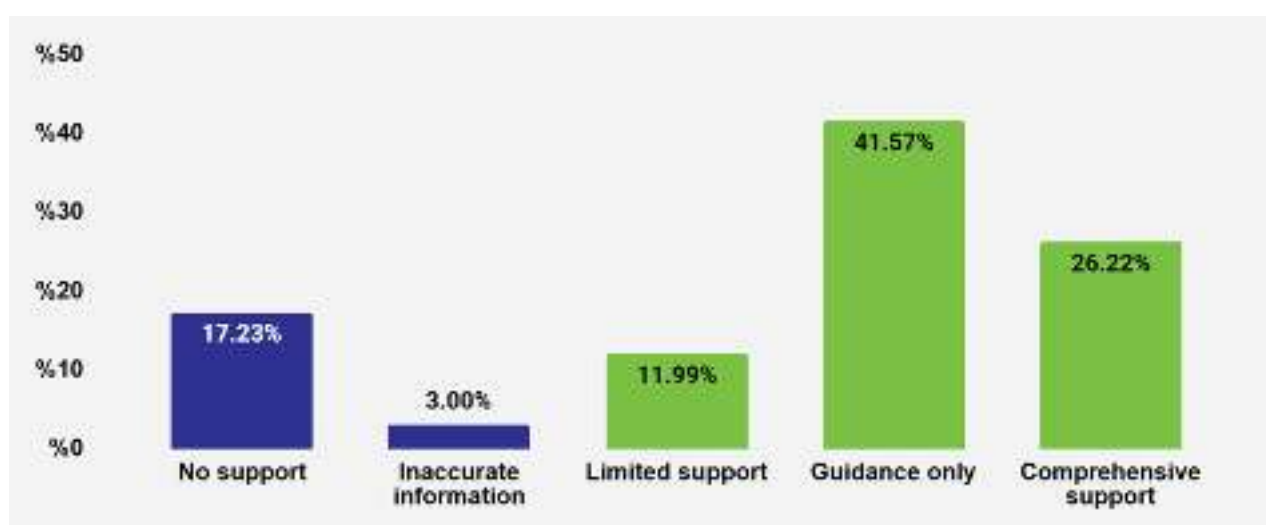
By analysing these dimensions, the chapter aims to provide a comprehensive overview of how post-arrival administrative procedures affect participants in practice. The findings highlight not only procedural differences across contexts but also the extent to which residence permit processes can either facilitate a smooth transition or create additional barriers during the mobility experience.

8.1. Level of Host Institution Support in Residence Permit Procedures

Host institution support regarding residence permit or registration procedures appears to have varied considerably across respondents. A total of 17.23% of respondents reported receiving no support, reflecting situations in which host institutions framed legal status procedures as entirely the responsibility of the participant. A further 3.0% indicated that the information provided was inaccurate, suggesting that a small but notable group experienced misleading or incorrect guidance. Additionally, 11.99% reported receiving only limited support in the form of verbal information.

By contrast, 41.57% of respondents received written guidance while completing the process independently, indicating that host institutions often played an informative rather than operational role. Finally, 26.22% described the support as comprehensive, demonstrating that in some cases institutions took a more active approach, such as arranging appointments or managing procedures collectively (Figure 46).

Figure 46



Types of Host Institution Support for Residence Procedures (N=267)

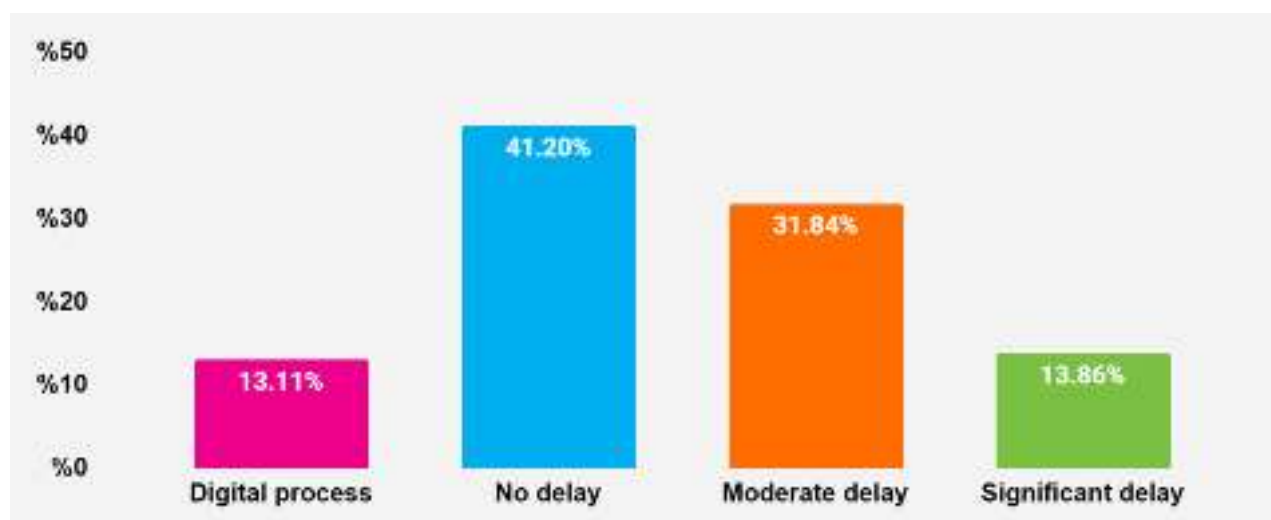
Overall, the distribution suggests that while many host institutions provided at least a basic level of guidance, the extent and quality of support were not consistent. For a substantial proportion of respondents, responsibility for navigating residence permit or registration procedures remained largely individual, even where some institutional guidance was available.

8.2. Time Required to Secure Residence Permit or Registration Appointments

Experiences related to securing residence permit or registration appointments show varying timelines following arrival, following the order of response options. A total of 13.11% (35 respondents) reported that the process was fully digital, indicating that in a minority of cases, appointments were not required or were managed entirely online.

The largest share, 41.20% (110 respondents), reported no delay, suggesting that they were able to secure an appointment shortly after arrival. In contrast, 31.84% (85 respondents) experienced a moderate delay, securing an appointment within one to three months, reflecting a more prolonged but still manageable waiting period. Finally, 13.86% (37 respondents) reported significant delays, with appointments obtained only after more than three months, highlighting a smaller but important group facing substantial administrative waiting times (Figure 47).

Figure 47



Timeframe for Securing Residence Permit or Registration Appointments After Arrival (N=267)

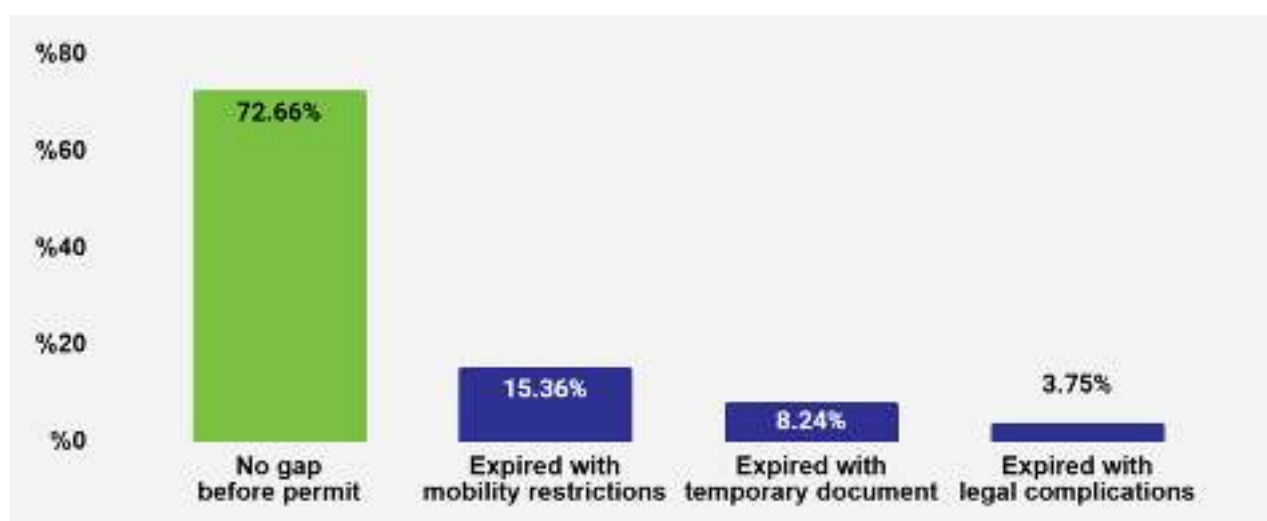
Overall, while many respondents were able to access appointments relatively quickly or through digital procedures, a substantial proportion experienced waiting periods extending over several months. This suggests that access to residence-related appointments may vary considerably depending on local administrative capacity and procedural requirements.

8.3 Continuity of Legal Status Between Visa Expiry and Residence Permit Issuance

Experiences related to the period between visa expiry and receipt of the physical residence permit card suggest that most respondents did not face a gap in legal status. A total of 72.66% reported that they received their residence permit before their entry visa expired, indicating that for the majority, the transition from entry visa to residence status was completed without interruption.

However, a notable minority experienced some form of legal limbo. 15.36% of respondents reported that their entry visa expired before they received the residence permit card, resulting in restricted mobility outside the host country. A further 8.24% indicated that although their visa expired, they were issued temporary documentation that allowed travel. A smaller share, 3.75%, reported that visa expiry led to legal or administrative complications (Figure 48).

Figure 48



Continuity of Legal Status Between Entry Visa Expiry and Residence Permit Issuance (N=267)

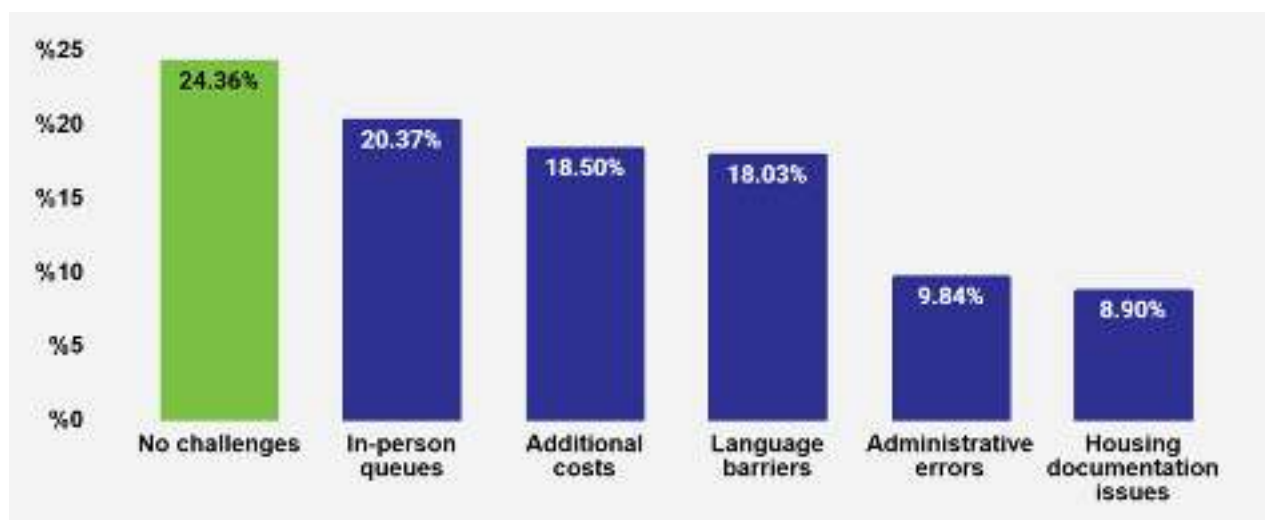
Overall, while most respondents did not encounter a gap between visa validity and residence permit issuance, the findings show that a considerable group experienced temporary uncertainty or limitations during this transition period. This suggests that delays in residence permit delivery can create practical and legal vulnerabilities even after arrival.

8.4. Challenges in the Residence Permit Application Process

Challenges encountered during the residence permit application process appear to have been diverse, although a substantial share of respondents reported no major difficulties. The largest category, 24.36%, indicated that the process proceeded smoothly, suggesting that for around one quarter of participants, residence permit procedures were completed without notable obstacles. However, the majority reported at least one form of challenge during the process.

Among the difficulties reported, extended in-person queues were the most common, cited by 20.37% of respondents, pointing to the burden of physical waiting times in order to access services or secure appointments. Unexpected additional costs, such as residence permit fees or mandatory insurance expenses, were reported by 18.50% of respondents. A similar share, 18.03%, identified language barriers as a key difficulty, suggesting that communication with authorities was not always fully accessible. Smaller but still relevant proportions reported administrative errors, including lost documents or the need to resubmit applications (9.84%), and housing documentation issues, where the lack of registered accommodation prevented submission of the application (8.90%) (Figure 49).

Figure 49



Reported Challenges in Residence Permit Application Processes (N=267)

Overall, the findings suggest that residence permit procedures often involved practical and administrative barriers beyond the formal application requirements themselves. While some respondents experienced a smooth process, many encountered challenges related to access, cost, communication, or documentation, indicating that post-arrival administrative procedures could still generate significant uncertainty and effort.

8.5 Impact of Residence Permit Delays on Access to Rights and Services

The impact of delays in the residence permit process on access to rights appears to vary across respondents. A majority, 64.42%, reported no restrictions, indicating that for many participants the timing of the residence permit did not significantly affect their ability to access services or opportunities.

However, a notable share experienced specific limitations. Travel restrictions were reported by 15.73% of respondents, reflecting situations where participants were unable to travel outside the host country or within the Schengen area while awaiting their residence permit. Financial restrictions affected 12.73% of respondents, including difficulties opening bank accounts or receiving grant payments. A smaller proportion, 7.12%, reported employment restrictions, such as being unable to work legally or undertake internships during the waiting period (Figure 50).

Figure 50



Impact of Residence Permit Delays on Access to Rights and Services (N=267)

Overall, while most respondents did not report restrictions, the findings suggest that delays in residence permit issuance can limit mobility, financial access, and employment opportunities for a meaningful minority of participants.



Chapter 9

Overall Experience



This chapter provides a synthesis of the key findings from the survey, bringing together respondents' future intentions regarding participation in mobility programmes and the main factors shaping these decisions. It moves beyond individual dimensions of the mobility experience to present a consolidated overview of how participants evaluate international mobility as a whole, particularly in relation to its perceived benefits and the barriers encountered throughout the process.

The analysis combines insights on future participation intentions with the underlying determinants influencing these choices, with a specific focus on administrative, financial, and procedural challenges. By integrating these perspectives, the chapter aims to offer a comprehensive understanding of how visa-related and structural factors interact with overall satisfaction and willingness to reapply for mobility opportunities.

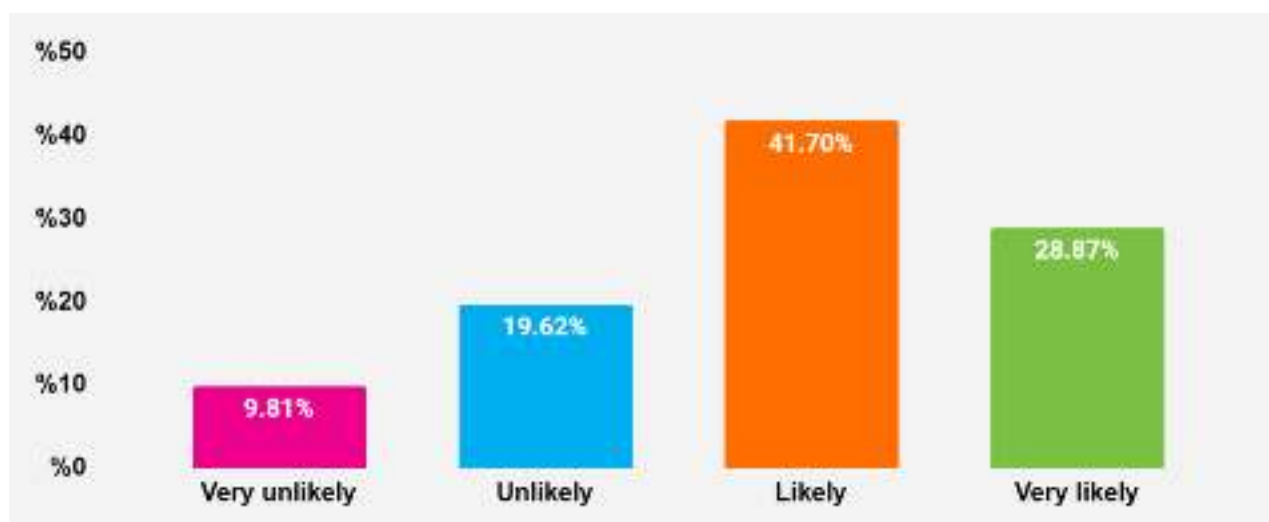
Together, these findings provide a holistic picture of mobility experiences, highlighting both the continued attractiveness of international mobility programmes and the persistent obstacles that shape participant decision-making.

9.1. Future Participation Intentions in Mobility Programmes

Among respondents, 28.9% (153) indicated they are very likely to apply for a similar mobility programme in the future, and 41.7% (221) stated they are likely to do so. A further 19.6% (104) reported being unlikely to reapply, while 9.8% (52) described themselves as very unlikely to participate in a similar programme again (Figure 51).

Despite the administrative, financial, and personal challenges documented throughout this report, 70.6% of respondents indicated they would likely or very likely apply for a similar mobility programme again. This reflects the enduring value respondents attach to international mobility itself rather than an absence of difficulty. The experience of navigating visa procedures, institutional bureaucracy, and post-arrival administrative requirements does not appear to have fundamentally diminished respondents' appetite for international participation, pointing to the resilience of mobility as an aspiration among non-EU students and young people.

Figure 51



Likelihood of Reapplying for a Similar Mobility Programme (N=530)

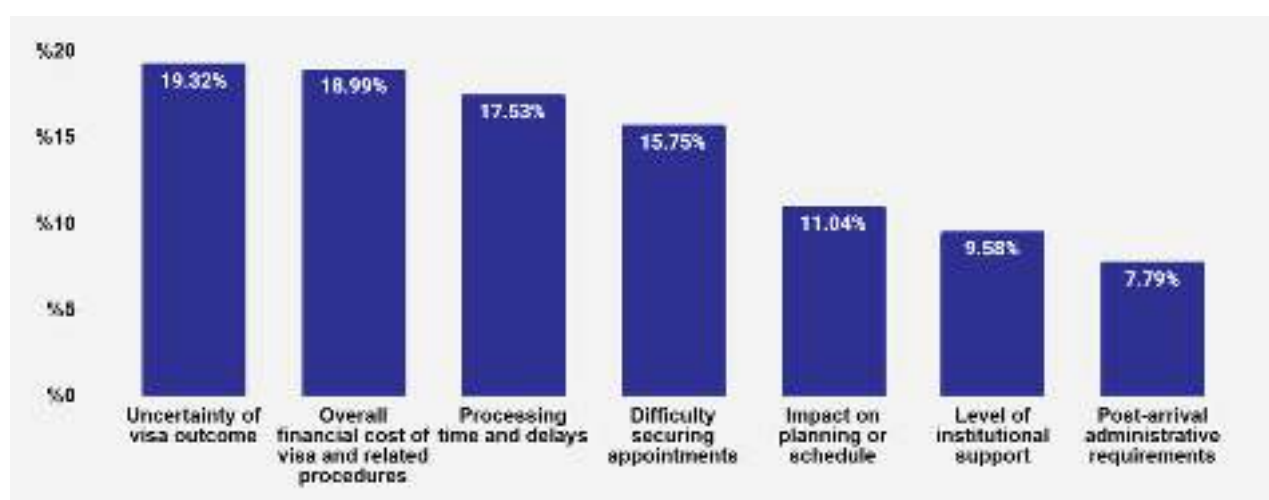
The 29.4% who expressed reluctance to reapply nonetheless represents a meaningful share of participants for whom the cumulative weight of visa-related procedures has translated into a tangible deterrence effect. That nearly three in ten respondents carry reservations about future participation is a finding that warrants attention, particularly given that those deterred may disproportionately include first-time travellers or those who encountered the most severe administrative and financial burdens during their mobility.

9.2. Factors Influencing Decisions to Participate in Mobility Programmes

The findings highlight that visa-related uncertainty and associated administrative and financial burdens are the most influential factors shaping respondents' decisions regarding mobility participation. The most frequently cited factor was uncertainty of visa outcome, reported by 19.32% (119 respondents), indicating that unpredictability in visa approval plays a major role in discouraging or complicating participation. Closely following were overall financial cost of visa and related procedures (18.99%, 117 respondents) and processing time and delays (17.53%, 108 respondents), both of which point to the significant economic and temporal burdens associated with mobility preparation.

Administrative challenges also emerged as important deterrents, with difficulty securing appointments accounting for 15.75% (97 respondents). In addition, 11.04% (68 respondents) reported that visa procedures had a direct impact on their planning or schedule, highlighting disruptions to academic and personal organisation. Although relatively less frequently cited, level of institutional support (9.58%, 59 respondents) and post-arrival administrative requirements (7.79%, 48 respondents) still represent notable concerns affecting the overall mobility experience. (Figure 52)

Figure 52



Key Factors Affecting the Decision to Apply for Mobility Participation (N=530)

Overall, the results suggest that while multiple factors contribute to decision-making, uncertainty, cost, and procedural inefficiencies are the dominant barriers, underscoring the need for more transparent, efficient, and financially accessible visa processes to support mobility participation.



➤ Conclusion

Conclusion

The findings of the Barriers of Mobility: Visa Issues for Non-EU Students – 2026 Edition demonstrate that visa and residence permit procedures play a central role in shaping access to international mobility. Rather than functioning as neutral administrative requirements, these processes act as structural factors influencing participation, experience, and outcomes across all stages of the mobility journey.

This report shows that mobility is not experienced under equal conditions, as administrative requirements introduce varying levels of complexity, uncertainty, and financial burden. While international mobility programmes aim to promote inclusion and equal opportunity, the persistence of such barriers continues to affect how and under what conditions students are able to participate.

1. Administrative Complexity as a Structural Barrier

The findings indicate that visa and residence permit procedures form a continuous and multi-layered administrative trajectory rather than isolated steps.

- A large proportion of participants are required to complete multiple overlapping procedures, often combining visa and residence permit applications.
- Administrative processes are characterised by inconsistency, limited transparency, and procedural uncertainty.
- Requirements and processes vary significantly across contexts, creating uneven experiences among participants.

2. Barriers to Access and Application Processes

Access to visa procedures emerges as a key challenge, particularly at the application stage.

- Many participants report difficulties in securing visa appointments, pointing to limited system capacity.
- Application systems are often described as unpredictable and difficult to navigate, with restricted entry points.
- Documentation requirements are frequently unclear or subject to change, resulting in additional or unlisted requests.

3. Financial and Time-Related Constraints

Visa-related processes introduce additional financial and temporal pressures that shape participation.

- Participants are often required to demonstrate financial resources beyond programme funding.
- Indirect costs, including service fees and travel for appointments, create additional financial strain.
- Processing timelines are highly variable, with some participants receiving decisions shortly before departure or after programme start dates.

4. Impact on Mobility Experience and Wellbeing

The effects of visa-related challenges extend beyond administrative procedures and influence the overall mobility experience.

- Delays and uncertainties contribute to disruptions in travel, accommodation, and academic integration.
- A considerable number of participants report negative impacts on wellbeing and stress levels.
- Missed orientation activities and late arrivals affect academic engagement and social integration.

5. Unequal Conditions of Participation

The findings point to differentiated experiences shaped by administrative requirements.

- Participants subject to more complex procedures report a stronger sense of disadvantage.
- Administrative requirements vary depending on passport context and regulatory frameworks, influencing access conditions.
- These differences contribute to a perception that mobility opportunities are not equally accessible to all.

Final Remarks

Ultimately, the findings underline that visa and residence permit procedures continue to shape international mobility in ways that go beyond administration, influencing both access and lived experience. While mobility programmes are grounded in the principle of equal opportunity, the persistence of complex, time-sensitive, and unevenly distributed administrative requirements suggests that participation is still conditioned by factors external to academic merit or motivation. As long as these structural differences remain, international mobility risks reflecting broader global inequalities rather than fully overcoming them, highlighting the importance of ensuring that access to mobility is experienced on more equal and consistent terms.

A photograph of three people standing behind a podium on a stage. The person on the left is a man with a beard, looking forward. The person in the middle is a woman with her hair tied back, speaking into a microphone. The person on the right is a man with glasses, standing with his arms crossed. They are all wearing dark blue shirts with logos. The podium has a large blue geometric logo on its front. A blue overlay covers the bottom half of the image, with the word 'Acknowledgements' in white text. A white arrow points to the left, partially overlapping the text.

Acknowledgements



Acknowledgements

The Erasmus Student Network Türkiye proudly acknowledges the collective effort, dedication, and support that made the Barriers of Mobility: Visa Issues for Non-EU Students – 2026 Edition possible. This research represents a significant step in amplifying the voices of non-EU students and contributing to a more inclusive and equitable international mobility landscape.

This report would not have been possible without the contributions of many individuals, volunteers, and partners:

- **The National Development Committee - Survey Team**, whose dedication and meticulous work in designing the questionnaire, managing data collection, and conducting the analysis formed the backbone of this report. Your efforts ensured that participants' experiences were captured accurately and translated into meaningful insights.
- **The ESN volunteers**, whose active involvement in dissemination, feedback, and outreach played a crucial role in reaching a diverse and representative group of respondents. Your enthusiasm and commitment to student mobility have been essential to this project's success.
- **ESN local sections and National Organisations**, who worked diligently to promote the survey and encourage participation across different contexts. Your efforts were key in ensuring that a wide range of student voices were included.
- **Partner institutions and organisations**, including universities, student organisations, and mobility stakeholders, whose support in outreach and visibility significantly contributed to the reach and impact of this research.

- **All contributors and reviewers**, whose expertise and constructive feedback strengthened the quality, clarity, and relevance of the final report.
- **Most importantly, the participants**, the hundreds of students and young people who shared their experiences. Your voices are the foundation of this report. By contributing your perspectives, you have helped highlight the realities of visa-related barriers and supported efforts toward meaningful change.

The success of this initiative reflects the strength of a community united by a shared commitment to improving international mobility. Together, we continue to advocate for a future where mobility opportunities are accessible, transparent, and equitable for all, regardless of nationality.

Best Regards,

Sedanur Demiral - National Development Committee Main Chair (25-26)

Ömer Çavuşoğlu - National Development Committee / Survey Team Vice Chair (25-26)

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ABBREVIATIONS

ESN — Erasmus Student Network

EU — European Union

ERASMUS - European Community Action Scheme for the Mobility of University Students

ESC — European Solidarity Corps

Non-EU — Non-European Union

PhD — Doctor of Philosophy

N — Sample Size



ABOUT ESN

The Erasmus Student Network (ESN) is the largest student organisation in Europe dedicated to supporting student mobility. Founded on October 16, 1989, and legally registered in 1990, ESN was established to facilitate student exchange. As a non-political, non-profit and non-religious organisation, ESN operates through a network of over 15,000 volunteers, active in more than 1,000 higher education institutions across 45 countries. Each year, ESN engages more than 29,000 young people, providing services to approximately 350,000 international students.

ESN aims to create a more mobile and flexible educational environment by promoting and enhancing student exchange opportunities. It also strives to offer an intercultural experience to students who are unable to participate in exchange programs, a concept known as 'Internationalisation at Home'. Guided by the principle of 'Students Helping Students', ESN's vision is to enrich society through international students, fostering global understanding and cooperation.

ESN is a full member of the European Youth Forum and the Advisory Council on Youth of the Council of Europe. Additionally, it is affiliated with several key international and European organisations, including the European Association for International Education, the Informal Forum of International Student Organisations (IFISO), the Global Student Forum (GSF), Generation Climate Europe (GCE), the International Association of Universities (IAU), the European Movement International (EMI), the European Citizen Action Service (ECAS) and the Lifelong Learning Platform (LLLP).



ABOUT ESN TÜRKİYE

ESN Türkiye is the national organisation of the Erasmus Student Network in Türkiye, a non-profit organisation dedicated to supporting international exchange students and promoting intercultural understanding. Established in 2006, ESN Türkiye operates through a growing network of local sections at universities across the country. As of 2026, it includes 38 active sections, each run by student volunteers who organize orientation programs, social activities, and academic support for incoming Erasmus students. The organization helps students adapt to life in Türkiye by providing guidance on accommodation, university procedures, and daily life, while also encouraging cultural exchange through events, trips, and workshops. In addition, ESN Türkiye contributes to increasing Türkiye's visibility as a study destination and supports returning Turkish students in readapting to their home environment after their Erasmus experience.



CONTACT

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